

ב"ה

יום

הכפורים

ה'תשע"ב

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סדר לילה

Note from the compiler:

Tishrei 5772

Dear Fellow Shliach,

Several years ago, I came to realization that the average person attending our high holiday services was not having the most fulfilling experience possible. The majority of people at my services were typical American Jews who appear at a synagogue two or three times a year. These wonderful Jews, while understanding the need to be in Shul during the high holy days, do not read or understand Hebrew nor are they familiar with the concept of davening. It dawned upon me that I had a unique responsibility to make these few hours as meaningful as possible and hopefully ignite the “pinteleh yid” thus encouraging more frequent participation at our Chabad events during the rest of the year.

Thus began the “rabbi’s talking points and prayer guide”. These notes are meant to infuse a potentially confusing experience with meaningful insight and clear prayer direction. All of the talking points contained herein are culled from various sources. 5772 marks the 8th year of this compilation.

This guide outlines select prayers which are said out loud in English, while others are sung together in Hebrew. Occasionally, you can ask a member of the congregation to share a prayer with everyone else.

Page numbers correspond to both the new and old Kehot machzorim: the first number represents the old and the second one the new.

Throughout these pages are icons that represent important points:



Announcement for the Rabbi



Prayer Insight



Chazzan Interaction



Recitation by a member(s) of the congregation



Humorous point

Typically, the rabbi should daaven beforehand which will allow him to speak freely the entire time. In order to make the guide easy to follow, every talking point and step of the service that is performed as a congregation is numbered and the rabbi moves forward from number to number as the services progress. The chazzan works together with the rabbi coordinating the services appropriately. He recites all the tefilos and will sing the central ones out loud. While the rabbi delivers a talking point, he continues quietly.

It is self-understood that no two congregations are alike. What may work at one may not necessarily be appropriate for another. For some, reciting tefilos in English may not be a good idea while for others more singing should be instituted. Ultimately, it is the responsibility of every Shliach to gauge the needs of his community and adapt accordingly.

I hope that you find this compilation helpful. With wishes for a גמר חתימה טובה.

Rabbi Simcha Backman
Glendale, California

Yom Kippur Eve

 Ladies and gentlemen, it is a time-honored, ancient Jewish custom to bless one's children at the start of this holiest of days. If your children are at your side, place your hand on their head, if they are not here with you, close your eyes and bring them close to you...if you don't have children, think of a close friend or a child by association. Let us together bless our loved ones that they have health, prosperity and the wisdom to do good...may they be like our forefathers and mothers, Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, Sarah, Rivkah, Rachel and Leah.

Silence...

1. Kol Nidrei Sermon



A History of Kol Nidrei

Although the Kol Nidrei prayer refers only to vows voluntarily made between a person and G-d, it nevertheless aroused accusations of untrustworthiness from non-Jews in many countries throughout the centuries. It was believed by some that because Jews said this prayer yearly, their vows were worthless. In medieval European courts Jews were required to take a special oath because of gentile suspicion of the effect of Kol Nidrei on testimony given by Jews.

In addition, the apostate Nicholas Donin (13th century) used the Kol Nidrei prayer to try to prove the perfidy of the Jews. This was such a widespread belief in 12th century France that perhaps for this reason and also for halachic reasons, Rabbi Jacob Tam (better known as Rabeinu Tam) changed the Kol Nidrei formula to refer only to vows made in the forthcoming year. This change has been incorporated in all Ashkenazi machzorim.

During the Inquisition in 15th century Spain, Kol Nidrei acquired a special resonance. Jews who had been compelled to adopt Christianity attended synagogues in secret and used Kol Nidrei as a means of renouncing what the Church had forced upon them.



All of the prayer books have the traditional Hebrew with a running English translation. G-d understands all languages.

We will announce page numbers so you know what page we are on. However that does not mean you have to keep turning the pages to keep up with the congregation. More important that keeping up with the congregation is that the prayers are meaningful to you. If a particular prayer speaks to you, spend time with it- meditating or reflecting on it. Prayer is a dialogue between you and G-d. Whatever page you are on is the right page.

The service may be different than what you are used to. Some of the prayers we will recite together in Hebrew, others in English and some we will sing together. If you are familiar with the tune, sing along, otherwise listen and learn. Throughout the services I will be interjecting explanations, stories and insight. Feel free to ask questions and discuss them.

If you have a question, feel free to ask me, Rabbi Backman or my wife Shterna.

Our custom is to stand whenever the ark is open. If you feel that you cannot stand every time the ark is open, that is OK, you may remain seated.

If you are asked to open the ark, or if you have a card which requires opening the ark, please approach the ark and open the doors when the rabbi signals.



Our souls are comprised of five spiritual levels. During the weekday, we access the three lower levels in our prayers. On Shabbat and holidays we access the fourth level. But it is only on Yom Kippur that it is possible for us to access the fifth, highest level – Yechidah – oneness with G-d, and only during Neilah, the final prayer service of the holiday.

The evening service – Maariv – corresponds to the lowest level of soul – Nefesh (spirit) – which relates to our biological life.

2. Page 23 [35] ה' מלך Recite in English

3. אור זרוע – שהחיינו TTO: Nusach



Two people flank the chazan holding Torah scrolls to form a Beit Din – a Jewish court, since Kol Nidrei and the following invitation to transgressors to join the services are considered legal proceedings.

In addition, when Moses prayed for success during the attack of the Amalakites against the Children of Israel in the desert, his arms were supported by Ahron and Chur (his brother-in-law, Miriam's husband). So too do we pray that we will be victorious over the Amalake within ourselves, our doubts of faith.



“Al daas haMakom... im haavaryanim” (“With the approval of the Ominpresent...we sanction prayer with the transgressors.”) Our Sages teach that a public fast in which Jewish sinners do not take part is no fast. This is derived from the fact that chelbana (galbanum) which has a foul aroma was included among the spices of the Temple incense. Rabbeinu Bachya (11th Century) explains that shows we should not ignore the sinners of Israel and exclude them from our fast and prayers, for when they repent and atone for their sins and join with the righteous, the Name of G-d is sanctified.

It is interesting that we are referring to ourselves in the third person, allowing ourselves into the congregation of prayer. Tzibur(TB”R) = Tzadikim, Benonim, Reshoim. This declaration in essence is saying that all Jews, regardless of background or “past performance” need to come together in a way of oneness to effect our atonement and intensify our personal connections to G-d.

 *“Kol Nidrei” “All vows ... will be null and void.” First step to entering the world of the soul is to be free of the bounds of the material world. The lowest soul level – nefesh – is the survival level. To get beyond this requires that we free ourselves of all biological life demands and traps since the survival mode creates all types of “vows”, habits and patterns that bind us; we must be free from them to truly grow.*

It is repeated 3 times corresponding to the 3 soul garments of thought, speech and action.

4. Page 24 [36] כל נדרי Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

 *“V’nislach” This is the climax of Moshe’s appeal for forgiveness after arousing G-d’s wrath by believing the spies’ claim that Israel was unconquerable.*

5. Page 24 [36] ונסלח Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

6. Page 24 [36] שהחיינו Sing in Hebrew

7. Page 24 [36] לכה דודי Sing in Hebrew [שבת Only]

8. Page 28 [43] ברכו Recite in Hebrew

 *The Shema - Hear O Israel, The Lord is our G-d, The Lord is one - is the quintessential statement of Judaism and Monotheism, expressing the unity of G-d, The Jewish People and the Torah.*

9. Page 29 [44] שמע Recite in Hebrew

 *The statement following the Shema “Baruch Shem...” is generally recited quietly. Only on Yom Kippur is it read aloud. We are taught that Moses originally heard this prayer from the angels when he was on Mount Sinai and brought it back down with him. He told the Israelites to say it quietly, because it was “stolen” from heaven. Thus we say it quietly all year round. But on Yom Kippur we are spiritually raised to the level of angels and we say the verse out loud and in public.*

 *The Shema is the ultimate expression of Divine unity. It declares not only that there is one G-d, but that there is nothing else other than G-d. G-d is one and the same as He was before and after the creation of the world, and all that exists is included within G-d.*

The recitation of the Shema is commanded by the Torah, and ought to be done with complete and undivided attention since it expresses the basic principle of Torah—the belief in Divine oneness—and it speaks of the Creator's relationship with humanity and with our evolving history.

Generally, the Shema is said out loud with the right hand lightly covering the eyes, in order to block out any extraneous distractions, and to help us go inward.

The Shema, says the Talmud, should be recited in "the language you hear," meaning the language you "know." This mandate also suggests that whatever you hear—in everything and through everything that you hear—you should sense Divine oneness.

Two letters of the Shema are written extra large in a Torah scroll: the ayin, the last letter of the word Shema ("hear") and the dalet, the last letter of the word echad ("one"). Taken together, these two letters spell aid, meaning "witness." By reciting the Shema, we bear witness to the Creator's oneness.

When the final word, echad, is pronounced, it is drawn out, with each letter distinctly audible. These letters are: alef (which has the numerical value of 1), chet (8), dalet (4). Accordingly, when pronouncing these letters, we should think about the oneness of the Creator permeating the eight levels of creation (the seven heavens and the earth), and the four corners or four dimensions of the world, thus making ourselves aware that all dimensions, as well as time and space, are included in the unity of the Creator. There is also a custom among some when pronouncing echad to move the head slightly—right, left, forward, back, down and up—to indicate that the oneness of G-d permeates all directions of creation.

The Zohar mentions that when we pronounce the word echad, we should meditate on being willing to give up our life for G-d, even imagining ourselves being consumed by fire, thus sanctifying G-d's name.

Symbolically, when we cover our eyes, we are momentarily, technically blind, and as "the blind is akin to the dead," so the covering the eyes suggest a death of a sort—a rapture, a state of ecstasy, an expiration of the soul. In the words of Rabbi Eliezer Ezkari (Late 1500s), it is as if "one died and is in front of the King."

In the opening statement of the Shema, plus the short statement that follows (Baruch Sheim), there are 49 letters, corresponding to the 49 gates of understanding, indicating that these passages of the Shema need to be absorbed intellectually, emotionally and ultimately factually.

10. Page 29 [44] ברוך *Recite in Hebrew and out loud*

11. Page 31 [46] השכיבנו *Recite in English*



Vidui – Confession

During the Amidah of Yom Kippur we recite a unique prayer called 'al chet'. This is meant to be an intimate moment when we acknowledge our iniquities before G-d who knows "the mysteries

of the universe and the hidden secrets of every human being.” The first essential step in teshuvah – repentance – is acknowledgement of the wrongdoing – the exact antithesis of denial. Repentance cannot be just a fleeting thought like other thoughts that come and go in a person’s mind. By acknowledging our sins in words, our repentance becomes much more real and help us reach the complete understanding that our sins are wrong and cannot be rationalized away.

We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

*Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.*

Sins in general are understood not as mere transgressions but as disconnections. When we sin we actually displace and disconnect ourselves from our own true self. As in is therefore not committed just against G-d, it is committed against the self as well. Teshuvah, which requires Viduy – confession – or acknowledgement, is the process of realigning and returning to our real self, our Divine soul.

In the Yom Kippur service, sins are expressed in the plural not only to save individuals from embarrassment but so that the congregation as a whole might attain true atonement. We cannot confess only for ourselves, rather we have to beg forgiveness for all Jews who sin. As the great 16th century Kabbalist, the Ari, said, “Confession is written in the plural, ‘we have sinned’ because all Israel is considered like one body and every person is a limb of that body. So we confess to all the sins of all the parts of our body.

Of course we should not feel limited to confess only the list of sins printed in the prayer book, we should also mention any specific sins which we may have committed.



Hashem Sifasai - A toddler, at first cannot walk, but quickly masters the art. A child fears water, but quickly learns to swim. Many of our limitations in life are more perceived than real.

In Hebrew the word for “lips” is the same for “river banks”. The banks of a river define its limitations. When we say “G-d open my lips” we are also saying “G-d help me to see beyond my perceived limitations”.



This prayer is called the “Amidah” the “standing” prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.

The Amidah is the central part of the service, it’s said every day of the year. It’s divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.

Praise: The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.

Petition: The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.

Thanksgiving: Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.

The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before G-d. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to G-d) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with G-d in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that G-dliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter G-d's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.

12. Amidah – A time for quiet reflection. G-d understands all languages.



“Ya’ale Tachanunaynu” (“May our supplications ascend”) This poem serves as an overall introduction to the prayers of Yom Kippur. It follows the reverse aleph beis order, showing after man reaches the full extent of his understanding; he must realize that he should go back to the beginning and deepen his spiritual understanding even more.

We beseech G-d to hear our prayers over the next 24 hours. We sing each stanza with the Chazan.



Yaale Tachenuneinu — Reflective Light

The usual acrostic pattern of the Piyutim (the special songs of the High Holidays) follows the Aleph Beit, beginning with the first letter aleph and following the established order. But here we find the order reversed, and there is a reason why.

There are two forms of light: 1) or yashar or direct light, and 2) or chozer or reflective light. The normal Aleph Beit order symbolizes the normal progression of direct linear light. But the reflective light emerges out of the darkness as even more powerful than the direct light, much like a mirror may reflect the rays of the sun light more intensely than the ray of sun itself.

Teshuvah is or chozer, reflective light that emerges from a darkness. And thus here, on Yom Kippur, with its focus on teshuvah, the order of this piyut is reversed.

We may sometimes feel like the last letter of the alphabet, but we should never despair since light can emerge even from the lowest of places, and sometimes that light is that much more bright.

13. Page 42 [58] יעלה Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

14. 🎵 Page 42 [58] יעלה TTO: Nusach



“Shomaya Tefillah” (“you who hearkens to prayers”)

We now begin the “Selichos” section- a collection of verses that express G-d’s greatness and willingness to forgive us. The composers of these supplications include some of the outstanding figures of Talmudic time or great Sages from later time periods. So understand that these

compositions are infinitely more than good poetry. They are more like writings of Divine inspiration.

In the evening service the Ark is opened anew for each hymn, indicating opening a new dimension of the soul. Each hymn is followed by reciting the 13 attributes of compassion, to be discussed later. In total the Ark is opened five times corresponding to the five levels of the soul.

15. Talking Point #1

For over a thousand years the Jewish people have gathered together on the opening moments of Yom Kippur to recite the prayer - Kol Nidrei. Its melody is universal it is meant to invoke within us an awesome sense of the day. It sets the mood for this evening and it sets the tone for the rest of Yom Kippur.

Yet, if you read the translation of the words we're about to recite they do not seem to be moving or inspirational, powerful or heart rendering.

The newspapers and media say tonight is the start of Yom Kippur, which begins with the reciting of the "Kol Nidrei" Why such attention? Why such emotion?

In 1492 the Jewish community of Spain was attacked thousands were massacred hundreds of thousands more expelled. Women and children sold into slavery and 200,000 became anusim (the forced ones) you may know them as marranos (a derogatory term). The anusim were forced to give up their Judaism and to convert to another faith. But yet deep inside they never gave up their beliefs, they never gave up their G-d, they never gave up their love for Judaism.

On this one night, on Yom Kippur, they would sneak into basements and cellars and they would say in whisper Kol Nidrei. Dear G-d, all these vows that I have taken in public please, I beg you dear G-d, annul them "lo shirrin v'lo kayomin." Let our vows not be considered vows, our oaths not considered oaths.

Their tears would flow down their cheeks as they would recite it a second time, and a third time. This was their Yom Kippur. This was their return. This was their connection.

We have continued their tradition of the Kol Nidrei for we too are "anusim". We too often hide our identity. We cover up who we really are or who we really should be.

Tonight, on Yom Kippur, on this the holiest day of the year the achas b'shono, the one time a year that our true identity must be revealed, tonight all our walls must come down.

The walls that separate us from G-d, that keep us at a distance from the divine, the walls that we've built around our own soul, protecting ourselves from answering its calling "give me purpose give me fulfillment give me spirituality" These walls come down tonight.

And yes, the walls that separate us and divide us from each other, the walls that create a barrier between us, these walls must come down.

So tonight, let your heart and mind wander... speak directly to G-d Al-mighty... tell him that you plan on making this year, this new year. A year in which the bond that connects you and G-d will be strengthened. Pour out your heart to him and he will hear. He will listen.. He will sooth... he will comfort.

16. Page 44 [61] Last 5 pesukim of Shomea Tefilah



Darkecha Elokeinu

After the sin of the Golden Calf, Moshe pleaded with G-d, "Let me know Your ways." In response, G-d taught him the 13 Attributes of Mercy, one of which is slow to anger.

17. Page 44 [61] דרכך Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

18. 🎵 Page 44 [61] דרכך TTO: Nusach



"13 Attributes of Mercy"

Moshe felt that Israel's sin of the Golden Calf was so grievous that there was not a possibility of his intercession on their behalf. Thereupon, G-d appeared to him in the guise of a chazzan wrapped in a tallis and taught him the 13 Attributes. G-d said, "Whenever Israel sins, let them recite this in the proper order and I will forgive them." This appeal for G-d's mercy reassures us both that teshuva is always possible and that G-d always awaits our return to Him.

19. Page 44 [62] ה' ה' Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

20. Page 45 [62] האזינה Recite in English



Penitential Prayers

Exclusive to Yom Kippur is an entire selection of penitential prayers which are recited in each of the five prayers (after the silent Amidah in the evening service, and in the cantor's repetition in the other services). In the evening service the Ark is opened anew for each hymn, indicating

opening a new dimension of the soul. Each hymn is followed by reciting the thirteen attributes of compassion – which were revealed to Moses atop Mt. Sinai before he descended on Yom Kippur. In total the Ark is opened five times corresponding to the five levels of the soul.

The penitential prayer in each of the five prayers consists of these special hymns:

Zachor Rachamecho – Remember your mercies (in Mussaf this is replaced with the Ten Martyrs – *eleh ezkera.*)

Zachor Lanu - Remember for us the covenant of the Patriarchs – Biblical quotations promising forgiveness.

Shema Koleinu – Hear our voice – heart-rending petitions to G-d imploring that he not reject us.



“S’lach Noh” (Pardon the wrongdoings)

The next two poems express our plea to G-d to forgive us, and our confidence in His willingness to do so. The beginning of each sentence paraphrases Moshe’s plea to G-d to forgive the Jewish nation after the sin of the Golden Calf. We sing each stanza with the chazan.

21. 🎵 Page 45 [63] סלח נא TTO: אבינו מלכנו חננו ועננו or אננים זמירות

22. Talking Point #2 [Break for אמנם כן]

The disciples of Rabbi Levi Yitzchak of Berditchev noticed that something was amiss.

Yom Kippur, the most awesome day of the year, was approaching, and it was only natural that every G-d-fearing Jew's steps should grow more measured, his mind more focused, his manner graver. But this was something else. A heavy foreboding clouded their master's features; his eyes had grown red from weeping, and an uncharacteristic sigh would often escape his lips. The Rebbe must know something we do not, they whispered. Perhaps he sees a terrible calamity decreed for the coming year, G-d forbid.

Several days before Yom Kippur, Rabbi Levi Yitzchak summoned his gabbai (secretary). Much to the gabbai's amazement, the Rebbe had business on his mind.

"Lately, the number of people coming to request that I pray for them on the Holy Day has been steadily increasing," said the Rebbe. "It's time we set a fixed price for the kvitlach. I think we should ask for two groschen for each name written in a kvitel."

When a chassid gives his rebbe the piece of paper (kvitel) on which his name and the names of his loved ones are inscribed for the rebbe to mention in his prayers, he always includes a sum of money, known as the pidyon nefesh (redemption of the soul), as a gift to the rebbe. As a rule, the sum is left to the petitioners discretion, which was why Rabbi Levi Yitzchak's gabbai was quite surprised by what the Rebbe was proposing.

So notices were put up in the synagogue and the market place, and soon the entire town had heard of the new rules: the Rebbe was demanding two groschen for each name.

Immediately after the morning prayers on the day preceding Yom Kippur, Rabbi Levi Yitzchak began receiving the kvitlach-bearers. A sense of urgency was felt throughout the town---the Rebbe's strange stipulation, coupled with his ominous behavior of the last few weeks, fed the feeling that it was of utmost importance to be included in the Rebbe's list. Two groschen was not such a great sum, but for an impoverished peddler or tailor with a dozen children to register, it was no small expense. Still, not a soul stayed behind. This year, no one was taking any chances.

All day the Rebbe sat, his faithful gabbai at his door, and received kvitlach. Soon his desk was covered with folded pieces of paper and copper coins. There were those who tried to bargain with the gabbai, but the Rebbe's instructions had been clear: no exceptions.

Around mid-day, a woman approached the gabbai and begged for an exemption. "I am a poor widow with an only child, without a single groschen in my purse. How can I pay four groschen so that my child and I may be inscribed in the book of life? Please, have mercy on me and my fatherless child, and allow me to add our names to the Rebbe's list. I promise to pay the entire sum as soon as I have the money."

"What can I do?" said the gabbai. "The Rebbe has told me that there are to be no exceptions."

"Let me ask the Rebbe," said the widow. "Certainly he will not turn me down."

The gabbai relented, but the Rebbe was unyielding. "I'm sorry," he said to the woman, "but these are the rules. Two groschen per name."

The widow left, heartbroken, but resolved to attain a year of life for herself and her child. One way or another, she would get the money. [Continued]

23. “Omnom Kayn” (“Indeed, it is true”)

Following from the theme of the previous prayer, this paragraph uses the refrain “Solachti”- paraphrasing G-d’s assurance to Moshe that He will forgive His people.

This was composed by one of the Tosafos, Rabbi Yom Tov ben Yitzchak of Joigny. In 1190, during the anti-Jewish riots that broke out in England following the coronation of Richard the Lion-Hearted, the Jews of York were confined to a castle and surround by an angry mob. At the urging of their leader, R’ Yom Tov, they decided to kill themselves rather than submit to forced baptism at the hands of the mob.

24. Page 46 [64] אבינו מלכנו (אדמו"ר הזקן) TTO: אמנם כן

 *Ki Hinei - in this song, we describe how our lives are in G-d’s hands- like clay in the sculptor’s hands or material in the weaver’s loom, our lives are molded by Him. We ask G-d to overlook our evil inclination that has led us to do wrong, and to rather recall His covenant to always look after us.*

25. Page 47 [66] כי הנה *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*

26. Page 47 [66] כי הנה TTO: Nusach

27. Page 48 [67] ה' ה' *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*

28. Talking Point #3 [Continued from above]

Hours passed. The last of the petitioners had already left, and the hour of Kol Nidrei, the solemn prayer which opens the Yom Kippur service, was fast approaching. The gabbai had cleared the table, counting the coins and locking them away, and packing the kvitlach in the special parcels which the Rebbe would keep with him during his prayers. Everyone was already in the synagogue, garbed in their snow-white kittelen and wrapped in their talitot, awaiting the Rebbe. Still Rabbi Levi Yitzchak lingered, his eyes casting expectant glances at the window.

Then, a small, shawled figure was seen hurrying along the deserted street. It was the widow, a folded piece of paper and a few coins in her hand. "Thank G-d the Rebbe is still home," she cried. "Here is my kvitel, Rebbe. Please pray for me and for my only child that we may be inscribed in the book of life."

"But you only have two groschen here," protested Rabbi Levi Yitzchak, peering at the coppers she had placed on the table. "So you can only write one name in your kvitel."

"Holy Rebbe," cried the woman, "I have been running about all day, borrowing from everyone that I know. This is all I was able to come up with. Please pray for us both! I promise to pay the rest within a week."

"I'm sorry," insisted the Rebbe, "the price is two groschen per name. Which name do you want in your kvitel?"

With trembling fingers the woman took her kvitel and crossed out her own name. "Pray for my Shloimehleh, Rebbe," she said, her eyes brimming with tears, "that he should have a year of life, health and happiness."

Upon hearing these words, the Rebbe's eyes came alive with a fiery light. Grasping the widow's two groschen in one fist, and her kvitel in the other, he raised them triumphantly to heaven and cried: "Father in Heaven! Look! Look what a mortal mother is prepared to do for her child! And You---shall it be said, G-d forbid, that You are less a parent to Your children?! Can You look this woman in the eye and refuse to grant Your own children a year of life, health and happiness?!"

"Come," said Rabbi Levi Yitzchak to his gabbai and to the widow, "let us go to Kol Nidrei."

☺ *Abe is talking to his friend. "If there's one piece of simple advice I can give you, Mervyn, it's this. I read it in the Times yesterday and it worked immediately for me.*

I've finally found inner peace. I'm sure it will work for you too."

"So give me this advice, already," says Mervyn.

"OK, here it is," replies Abe, "the way to achieve inner peace is to finish all the things you've started."

"Really?" says Mervyn.

"Yes," replies Abe. "I looked around to see all the things I had started but hadn't finished. So, I finished one bottle of white wine, a bottle of red wine, a keg of beer, the bottle of whiskey, and a large box of gourmet chocolates. You have no idea how good I felt."



“Shema Kolaynu” (“Hear our voice”)

We repeat the next four lines responsively after the chazan.

Each line highlights our plea to G-d not to abandon us and to have mercy on us at this crucial time.

29. Page 50 [70] שמע קולנו Recite in Hebrew and in English



“Ki Onu Amecha”

We joyfully describe the unique closeness to G-d that we, as the Jewish nation, enjoy. It first lays out 12 aspects of the parallel relationship we have with G-d, and then 4 aspects of our sin and inadequacy, but G-d is merciful and infinite, therefore we confess our sins and seek His forgiveness.



“Oshamnu” (“We have transgressed”)

The next section follows the order of the Hebrew alphabet and forms a general confession. We lightly hit our chest with our right hand while saying each phrase in this paragraph.

30. Page 52 [73] אתה יודע Recite in English



We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit

Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit

Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.

31. 🕯 Page 55[76] Congregant 1: David

32. 🕯 Page 55[77] Congregant 2: Micah

33. 🕯 Page 55[77] Congregant 3: Daniel

34. 🕯 Page 55[77] Congregant 4: Ezra

35. 🕯 Page 57[80] רחמנא Recite in English, Sing in Hebrew



Avinu Malkaynu is one of the most famous prayers of the Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur service. It was introduced by the great Talmudic sage, Rabbi Akivah almost 2000 years ago. At that time no other form of prayer was successful in relieving a devastating drought that

gripped Israel. As soon as Rabbi Akivah used this formula to ask for rain, it immediately began to rain.

Since then, Avinu Malkaynu has occupied a very important place in our prayers. Reflects a dual relationship of intimacy and awe we have with Hashem. He is our King with complete control and absolute power over us. Yet he is also our Father, denoting the compassion, love, care and mercy He extends to us despite our errors of the past. This theme is central and integral to the High Holidays.

One of the ten melodies composed by the Alter Rebbe. The soulful melody, matching the earnestness of the text, is divided into three parts. The first, wordless, elevates the singers to a deeply spiritual mood. The second expresses yearning for the Divine, while the third is a declaration of faith in the help of our Father and King.

36. Page 57 [80] אבינו מלכנו *Recite in Hebrew Sing First and Last*
[Not said on שבת]

 *Psalm 24 – Said with tremendous focus and concentration it is a segulah, golden opportunity, to create the special vessel for G-d's blessings of sustenance and livelihood. The first line states that “the earth and all therein is the L-rd's”. This is the key to success, knowing where source of the blessings is and acting accordingly.*

37. Page 59 [82] לדוד מזמור *Recite in English*

 *Aleinu, according to early Rabbinic sources was a declaration of faith and dedication composed by Joshua after he led Israel across the Jordan river. The Bach (Rabbi Yoel Sirkis 1561-1640) explains that Aleinu was added to the daily prayers to implant faith in the Oneness of G-d's kingship, and the conviction that he will one day remove detestable idolatry from the earth. As we can surmise from its authorship and its placement at the conclusion of every service, its significance is profound.*

38. Page 60 [85] עלינו *Sing in Hebrew*

39. עשה שלום *Sing in Hebrew*

40. Talking Point #4 – Closing Remarks

Tonight we will begin a 25 hour fast of Yom Kippur. We don't do this in order to afflict ourselves. Indeed Yom Kippur is not a day of mourning but a day of joy. We fast on Yom Kippur because on this day we want to transcend our physical limitations and be like angels, and food and other physical concerns distract us from our spiritual selves.

Some people may complain that the hunger distracts them from concentrating on the prayers and rituals of the day. But this is precisely the Yom Kippur challenge, not to be overly focused on the physical.

Use the opportunity of not eating or drinking to allow yourself to experience the food and drink that comes from deep within. Fasting will then become a very freeing experience.

Yom Kippur is the one day in the year when you can access the deepest part of your soul. But this is only possible if you create the space for it. Your soul, every soul, has a still soft voice that emits a unique hum. This sound can only be heard if you lower the noise in your life that usually drowns out your inner voice.

On Yom Kippur, when the “source” is nearest to the “spark” of your soul, you want to remove as many material distractions as you can, so that your soul can sing freely and your “spark” can dance.

When you experience Yom Kippur this way, which does take effort, then it will not be a day when you feel hungry, but a day when you feel angelic.

Instead of indulging in physical pleasures, we spend the day in prayer, our whole intention being to transcend the physical world, our material home, and to travel inward to our purest spiritual selves, toward our true home in G-d.

41. **Announce service times for tomorrow:**

- Morning Services: 10:00 AM
- Torah Reading: 11:30 AM
- Yizkor Services: 12:30 AM
- Mincha Services: 5:30 PM
- Neilah Services: 6:30 PM

42. It is important to note that there are five prohibitions on Yom Kippur, namely:

1. Eating and drinking
2. Anointing with perfumes or lotions
3. Marital relations
4. Bathing

5. Wearing leather shoes

℞ These five “afflictions” correspond to the five books of the Torah which we accept without allowing our physical needs to intervene. They also correspond to the five senses with which man performs mitzvos and commits transgressions; to the five times the term nefesh is mentioned in the Yom Kippur Torah reading; to the five immersions of the Kohen Gadol on Yom Kippur day when the Temple stood; and to the five prayer services prescribed for the day: Maariv, Shacharis, Musaf, Mincha and Neilah.

יום הכפורים

ה'תשע"ב



סדר יום

Yom Kippur Shacharis

 All of the prayer books have the traditional Hebrew with a running English translation. G-d understands all languages.

We will announce page numbers so you know what page we are on. However that does not mean you have to keep turning the pages to keep up. More important that keeping up with the congregation is that the prayers are meaningful to you. If a particular prayer speaks to you, spend time upon it in meditation and reflection. Prayer is a dialogue between you and G-d. Whatever page you are on is the right page.

The service may be different than what you are used to. Some of the prayers we will recite together in Hebrew, others in English. Some will be sung out loud. If you are familiar with the tune, sing along, otherwise listen and learn. Throughout the services I will be interjecting explanations, stories and insight. Feel free to ask questions and discuss them.

If you have a question, feel free to ask me, Rabbi Backman or my wife Shterna.

Our custom is to stand whenever the ark is open. If you feel that you cannot stand every time the ark is open, that is OK, you may remain seated.

If you are asked to open the ark, or if you have a card which requires opening the ark, please approach the ark and open the doors when the rabbi signals.

 Our souls are comprised of five spiritual levels. During the weekday, we access the three lower levels in our prayers. On Shabbat and holidays we access the fourth level. But it is only on Yom Kippur that it is possible for us to access the fifth, highest level – Yechidah – oneness with G-d, and only during Neilah, the final prayer service of the holiday.

The morning service – Shacharit – corresponds to the second level of soul – Ruach (breath) – which relates to our emotional life and the prayers of the morning service are seen through the lens of ruach. Although all prayer is about emoting with G-d, the root of it all begins in the morning service of Yom Kippur, which reveals the ruach dimension of your soul.

1. Page 85 [121] שיר למעלות Recite in English

 Hodu - According to some Jewish Scholars this prayer is the oldest, continuously said, component of our daily prayers. It has been recited for some 3000 years by the Kohanim even before construction of the Temple, then subsequently by the general Jewish population and it was eventually incorporated into the Ashkenazik prayer book and then adopted by Sefardic Jews.

Hodu ("give thanks") is the official beginning of the "Verses of Praise," and it is here that we ascend to the second rung on the ladder of prayer. This second segment of the prayer corresponds in Kabbalah to the world of formation (yetzirah), and the level of soul known as ruach, which means "spirit" and signifies emotional consciousness.

In this segment of prayer, we continually praise G-d for the revelation within nature and within history, for the wonders of creation, and for the miracles performed throughout the ages. These verses of praises were instituted for two primary reasons: first of all, to emulate the prayers of Moshe, who first praised G-d, then asked for his needs. By evoking Moshe's prayers, our own prayers are thus assisted. And secondly, by praising G-d, we are inspired and brought into the requisite state of joy.

Overall, this part of prayer is meant to be joyful and recited with an openness of heart. Whereas the word zimra is translated as "praise," it is also related to zemer meaning to "uproot/cut off." In these prayers, we cut away all our wrong desires and chip away at negativity. Yet, in so doing, we do not mean to expunge desire itself, rather to change its trajectory—that is, praise of G-d inspires a radical reorientation of our entire emotional reality.

2. Page 87 [123] הודו לה' Sing in Hebrew



Hoaderes - recited by the angels singing the praises of G-d. Meaning: all attributes that can be enumerated true and perfect only when applied to G-d, who is eternal and absolutely perfect. When applied to moral human being, they are not true since we have a limited life on earth and all his qualities are necessarily limited and imperfect. This should inspire a profound sense of humility.

3. Page 88 [125] האדרת Sing in Hebrew



Baruch Sheomar - this prayer is attributed to the men of the great assembly (Sanhedrin). According to tradition it was revealed from heaven with eighty seven words that correspond to the numerical value of the Hebrew word PAZ meaning "Refined Gold"

This blessing serves as an opening for the "Verses of Praise" (Pesukei De'Zimra). In the following passages of praise, we tell of the greatness of the Creator and the way He is manifest within creation, with the aim of arousing our emotions.

As an initiation to these verses, we recite "Blessed is He Who spoke..." (Baruch Sheamar), a prayer which expresses the wonder and awe of creation and how it is continually being recreated by Divine word.

Although creation had a beginning, it is continuous. G-d creates and recreates this world anew with each moment. This is an empowering thought to contemplate—that each moment gives us an opportunity to return to G-d in teshuvah, to start anew no matter what our previous errors were.

Thus, the first letters of the opening words Baruch Sheamar V'haya Ha'olam ("Blessed is He Who spoke and the world came into being")—beit, shin, vav, hei—spell out "return." We can

only return to G-d through teshuvah if we are fully aware of the continuous renewal of creation. This gives us hope. If time would only flow linearly, then the past would inevitably dictate the present and future, and there would be no hope for us. But, when we are aware of the continuous flow of creation—that each moment represents a fresh beginning—we can pray with unimpaired joy.

Baruch Sheamar contains 87 words, which is the numerical value of the word paz, meaning "pure gold." As it says in Psalms (21:4): "You set on his head a crown of pure gold (paz)." This, then, is a prayer of the finest quality, and it is also the golden crown of the entire Pesukei De'Zimra.

The word baruch ("bless") appears thirteen times in this prayer. The number 13, the numerical value of echad (meaning "one"), inspires us to realize the oneness, uniformity and harmony within nature.

✚ During this prayer we gather together the two front fringes of our prayer shawl (tzitzit), an action which evokes the Source of all blessings, G-d. G-d's essential four-letter name—spelled yud, hei, vav, hei—has the numerical value of 26. Each corner fringe of the prayer shawl has 8 strings and 5 knots, adding up to 13, and when we gather the two front fringes together, we hold 26.

4. Page 89 [125] ברוך שאמר Recite in English



Mizmor Shir - Shabbat & Teshuvah - The Midrash tells us that following the brutal murder of his brother Hevel, Kayin was summoned to the heavenly tribunal for judgment. After a brief deliberation, it was decreed that Kayin would be condemned to a life of wandering: "You shall become a vagrant and wanderer on earth." Acknowledging the gravity of his iniquities and accepting his sentence, Kayin beseeched the court for mercy, asking, "Is my iniquity too great to be borne?"

Upon leaving the heavenly court, Kayin was met by Adam, his father. Seeing his son's jubilant disposition, Adam inquired of Kayin as to what had occurred in the court. When Kayin told him what he had done and that he had left the court with a clean slate, Adam said, "Such is the power of teshuvah, and I did not know it." He then began to sing "a Psalm, a Song for Shabbat day." The amazing transformative potential of teshuvah aroused Adam to compose a song in honor of the sacred day of Shabbat.

Shabbat and teshuvah are both similar in that they are both liberating agents. They spiritually free the human being from the normal course of unfolding reality. Shabbat exists as a refuge in time—no matter how absorbed we may be during the course of the week, we have a sacred time of refuge, when we are able to rest and reflect. Teshuvah is a refuge in place for the soul.

If we have drifted away from G-d and become alienated from the true source of our soul, teshuvah gives us a space where we can find refuge. In this space we can redefine and recreate our inner self and become reborn once again.



In Ashrei we find the 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet encoded in the prayer. The first letter in each of the first 22 words is the alphabet in its correct order. Because the Hebrew letters are actual instruments of creation, this prayer helps to inject order and power into our lives. We can gain control over our world by tapping the forces that created it. Interestingly, the only letter left out of this prayer is the “nun”. King David wisely left it out since nun is the letter that begins spelling the Hebrew word for falling... “nofel” ... falling refers to a spiritual decline. Feelings of doubt, depression, worry, and uncertainty are consequences of spiritual falling.

"Happy are they who dwell in Your house and praise You continually..." From this verse (of Psalm 85:5), the Talmudic sages found support for the proper preparation for prayer: first settle the minds and then pray. First dwell in the home then offer praise. (Tosefos, Berachos 32b)

Additionally, the nun refers to the mystery of the fallen Shechinah—the Presence of G-d, which is in exile now, as we read in the Book of Amos (9:11) "the canopy of David that is falling"—falling now. What we need to do is elevate the Shechinah, and bring about the unification between the higher spiritual world and the lower physical world.

This is why this Psalm opens with: "A Psalm of praise by David: I will elevate You," meaning "I will elevate/lift up the Shechinah." And this we do by offering praise to G-d.

This introduction is then followed by Psalm 145. According to the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 4b), any individual who recites this Psalm three times daily is certain to experience the World to Come. For this reason it is included in the prayers three times, twice in the morning prayers, and once in the afternoon prayers.

By meditating on the meaning of its verses, we are assured of being strengthened in our belief and resolve, and because of that, we will inherit life in a future world.

5. Page 90 [127] אשרי Recite in English or Sing in Hebrew

6. Talking Point #1

“What if the Secret to Success Is Failure?”

That was the tantalizing title of the lead story in the New York Times Sunday magazine a few weeks ago. The article makes us rethink an attitude that has become culturally accepted as unquestioned truth, and more profoundly, its conclusions encourage us to acknowledge the wisdom of Jewish tradition and the insights it asks us to emphasize in our observance of Yom Kippur.

Yom Kippur is a day dedicated to acknowledging our failings.

Over and over again we repeat the words, "I have sinned." We recognize that in many ways we "missed the mark," the literal translation of the Hebrew word for sin. We admit we weren't perfect. If we were to be graded by God for our actions during the past year, we confess that in some areas we deserve an F.

And yet whoever heard of a mark like that in our contemporary culture?

For decades now parents have been told by many ostensible experts that all they are permitted to do in rearing children is to praise them. Criticism is always destructive of self-esteem, and self-esteem is the highest value we must pass on to our progeny. Make them feel good about themselves; that way they will feel happy and self contented. Don't ever burden them with the verdict that they have failed to fulfill any objective. Don't ever crush their spirits by telling them they could've done better. Rewards, not criticism or punishments, are what children need to become responsible adults.

The teaching profession, too, was slowly drawn into this philosophy of "praise at all costs" without any reminders of failure. Grade inflation turned everyone into a scholar, because "he tried his best and he might feel bad if he didn't get an excellent mark." Valedictorians were eliminated in many schools because those who didn't earn the honor felt the loss of self-esteem, and it just didn't seem right to acknowledge that some weren't as perfect as others. More liberal schools eliminated competitive sports - or if they had them, rejected keeping score - so that nobody would ever have to admit to being a loser.

But what if the real secret to success is failure?

What if we need to keep score in our own lives and to acknowledge our errors, our weaknesses, and our failings if we are ever to improve and become what we are capable of becoming?

The New York Times article is an eye-opener because it forces us to confront what previous generations knew and we chose to forget: Recognizing our shortcomings is the only way to achieve success in life.

Paul Tough, the author of the essay (the appropriateness of his last name is stunningly obvious), concludes his lengthy analysis with this observation: Most Riverdale students can see before them a clear path to a certain type of success. They'll go to college, they'll graduate, they'll get well-paying jobs — and if they fall along the way, their families will almost certainly catch them, often

well into their 20s or even 30s, if necessary. But despite their many advantages, Randolph [the headmaster of this exclusive and very wealthy school] isn't yet convinced that the education they currently receive at Riverdale, or the support they receive at home, will provide them with the skills to negotiate the path toward the deeper success that Seligman and Peterson hold up as the ultimate product of good character: a happy, meaningful, productive life. Randolph wants his students to succeed, of course — it's just that he believes that in order to do so, they first need to learn how to fail.

To learn how to fail is nothing less than a succinct five word summary of the Yom Kippur confessional. It requires us to be mature enough to face up to the personal failings which well-meaning parents, teachers and friends tried to shield us from recognizing. It asks us to admit we're not perfect precisely because we're willing to take on the challenge of perfecting ourselves.

On Yom Kippur we have to define ourselves in light of a concept that Benjamin Barber, a political scientist at Rutgers University, believes is an ultimate truth about human behavior. We love to categorize people, usually by labeling them by one of two distinctly different characteristics. People are skinny or fat, introverted or extroverted, optimists or pessimists, serious or funny. All of these lead to stereotyping and to generalizations that aren't completely accurate. But there is one division of people that Barber claims is the most crucial and correct way to differentiate between them. He says:

I don't divide the world into the weak and the strong, or the successes and the failures, those who make it or those who don't. I divide the world into learners and non-learners - those who acknowledge their failures, learn from them, and move forward as opposed to those who can't admit ever having done anything wrong, never learn from their mistakes, and doom themselves to reliving the errors of their ways.

That's why on Yom Kippur, when we're asked to reflect upon whether our lives can be considered a success, we're judged by whether we're courageous enough to confess our sins and to admit our failures.

To acknowledge, to God and to ourselves, where we've gone wrong in our lives doesn't diminish us. On the contrary, it affords us the wisdom and strength to grow and to improve.

S. I. Hayakawa, former U.S. senator from California and a specialist in semantics, alerted us to an all-important distinction between two English words that most of

us assume are identical: “Notice the difference between what happens when a man says to himself, ‘I have failed three times,’ and what happens when he says, ‘I am a failure.’” To think of yourself as a failure is to create a perpetual self-image as a loser. But if you learn from your experience, if your failure inspires you to surpass yourself and to do it better next time, if you understand that failure is merely a momentary event but doesn't define you—then you are an alumnus of the best school in the world, and your failure was the tuition you paid for your eventual success.

On Yom Kippur we evaluate ourselves. On Yom Kippur we are critical of our failings. On Yom Kippur we don't deny our sins - we build on their memory for spiritual growth.

On Yom Kippur we realize the truth that failure - acknowledging it, learning from it, and rising from it - is really the secret of success.

☺ *Abe and Esther were not a very religious couple but tried their best. They only went to synagogue once a year.*

As they were leaving the synagogue, the Rabbi said, "Abe, it sure would be nice to see you and Esther here more than once a year"

"I know," replied Abe, "We're very busy people, leading active lives but at least we keep the Ten Commandments" "That's great," the Rabbi said. "I'm glad to hear that you keep the Commandments."

"Yes, we sure do" Abe said proudly, "Esther keeps six of them and I keep the other four".

7. Page 96 [134] נשמת *Recite in English*

 **Hamelech** - The loud cry of Hamelech – “O KING” - has the mystical effect of driving away the accusers from the throne of judgment... it is like when a captive passing the palace screams out “O KING” his captors fearing the king's wrath flee in panic... so to at the time of judgment we call out for the king's mercy and the accusatory angels are dispersed

8. Page 100 [135] בפי *Recite in English*

 **Yishtabach** - There are 15 expressions of praises to G-d in this paragraph similar to the 15 ascending steps at the Temple in Jerusalem. Our relationship with G-d must be handled, as we deal with life, one step at a time. Sure one can bound up two steps at a stairway, but don't try

it in life... each step is a message, an indispensable part of the life that molds and shapes our character. Similarly, our relationship with G-d is multifaceted, subtle, and sublime. Our inner lives must be fashioned one step at a time. These 15 expressions of praise reach ever higher and deeper.

The verses of praise, Pesukei De'Zimra, began with a blessing (Baruch Sheamar) and concludes with a blessing (Yishtabach), even if this final blessing does not begin in the standard manner of "Blessed are You..." (Baruch Ata).

After singing G-d's praises for the wonders of continued creation and the miracle of the splitting of the sea, we conclude with the words, Yachid, Chei Ha'olamim, meaning "Unified, the Life of [all] the worlds."

There are two ways in which we speak of G-d as the life force. One is to say that G-d is Chei Ha'olamim and the other is Chai Ha'olamim. While both are translated in English as "Life of the worlds." In Hebrew, there is a subtle difference between the two. The word chei is a descriptive phrase, meaning "life of..." But the word chai is a noun, meaning "life." Thus, when it refers to G-d, chei denotes the "Life force of the world"—that light that is connected to, and permeates, this universe. Chai, on the other hand, denotes the light that is transcendent, hovering above the world.

Having explored nature and the miracles of nature, we come to an awareness that both the immanent light and the transcendent light are manifestations of one unified light, reflecting the finite and the infinite.

9. Page 100 [136] ישתבח Recite in English



Shir HaMaalos (Psalm 130) - Written by King David, this prayer evokes forgiveness and supplication. It opens with "from the depth of my heart I call to you" – our prayers to G-d need to come from deep within and should not be superficial mumblings of words but rather a service of the heart and soul.

10. Page 100 [136] שיר למעלות Recite in English



Kaddish - In the prayer service, whenever there is a change between prayers, a break or movement, a special prayer called a kaddish ("sanctification" of the name of G-d) is recited in order to bring unity.

Whenever there is a separation in the prayers—or for that matter a "break" in life itself—we recite the Kaddish and declare, "Magnified and sanctified may His great name be..." Thus, we ensure that His name, the Source of all, is brought together in harmony, and a healing on all levels of existence takes place.

The essential four-letter name of G-d—spelled in Hebrew yud-hei-vav-hei—can be viewed as containing two parts. The first yud-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 15, represents the spiritual transcendence; the second vav-hei, whose numerical equivalent is 11, represents the physical immediate. This separation is the root cause of all dissension and separations, death included.

By reciting the Kaddish, "yisgadal veyiskadash," which contains eleven letters, we reunify the name and inspire a total reunification of the entire world.

11. Page 101 [137] ברכו *Recite in Hebrew*



Barchu - The Zohar teaches that "all things holy need summoning." And so the leader of the prayers begins with, "Bless G-d!," calling the entire congregation to bless G-d, adding, "Who is blessed" so as to include himself within the community. The congregation responds with, "Blessed be G-d," adding "Who is blessed forever and ever," implying that G-d is blessed by all—the lowly creatures and the heavenly, above and below.

The five Hebrew words of the response correspond to the five levels of soul, which become fully integrated by the reciting of the blessing.



We bend our knees and bow saying these words as we become open to G-d's blessings by humbling ourselves. The word for "bless" (barchu) shares its root with the word for "knee" (beirach), and so we bend our knees as we open ourselves to receive G-d's blessings.

12. Page 102 [138] א-ל אדון *Sing in Hebrew [Only Shabbos]*

13. Page 104 [140] קדוש *Recite in Hebrew*

14. Page 104 [140] ברוך *Recite in Hebrew*

15. Page 104 [140] לא-ל ברוך *Sing in Hebrew*



Ahavas Olam - Unity through Humility

Ahavas Olam is a prayer for unity. When we say, "bring us in peace from the four corners of the earth," we gather the four fringes (tzitzit) from the four corners of the prayer shawl (talit). In absolute reality, there is total unity, but in our world, there seems to be disharmony and division. There are corners/parts to the world. And so, we take the four fringes, which have 32 strings, and bring them together as one, holding them in the left hand and placing them against the heart for the reading of the Shema.

The number 32 denotes the paths of chochmah ("wisdom") and the idea of bitul ("self-nullification"), which open us up to a higher reality. By bringing the 32 strings together, we evoke the power of chochmah and the idea of bitul-ego abandonment, and through that, we bring peace, harmony, and unity to our own microcosmic world and to the macrocosmic world of which we are a part.

The talit together with its tzitzit embraces both unity and diversity. The multiplicity is represented by the fringes on the corners, but the fact that they are part of one garment represents the interconnectedness between all the apparent separate forces. Bringing the corners together as one, we are ready for the Shema-the quintessential statement of G-d's oneness.

16. Page 104[140] אבינו – והאר Sing in Hebrew



The Shema - Hear O Israel, The Lord is our G-d, The Lord is one - is the quintessential statement of Judaism and Monotheism, expressing the unity of G-d, The Jewish People and the Torah.

The Shema is the ultimate expression of Divine unity. It declares not only that there is one G-d, but that there is nothing else other than G-d. G-d is one and the same as He was before and after the creation of the world, and all that exists is included within G-d.

The recitation of the Shema is commanded by the Torah, and ought to be done with complete and undivided attention since it expresses the basic principle of Torah—the belief in Divine oneness—and it speaks of the Creator's relationship with humanity and with our evolving history.

Generally, the Shema is said out loud with the right hand lightly covering the eyes, in order to block out any extraneous distractions, and to help us go inward.

The Shema, says the Talmud, should be recited in "the language you hear," meaning the language you "know." This mandate also suggests that whatever you hear—in everything and through everything that you hear—you should sense Divine oneness.

Two letters of the Shema are written extra large in a Torah scroll: the ayin, the last letter of the word Shema ("hear") and the dalet, the last letter of the word echad ("one"). Taken together, these two letters spell aid, meaning "witness." By reciting the Shema, we bear witness to the Creator's oneness.

When the final word, echad, is pronounced, it is drawn out, with each letter distinctly audible. These letters are: alef (which has the numerical value of 1), chet (8), dalet (4). Accordingly, when pronouncing these letters, we should think about the oneness of the Creator permeating the eight levels of creation (the seven heavens and the earth), and the four corners or four dimensions of the world, thus making ourselves aware that all dimensions, as well as time and space, are included in the unity of the Creator. There is also a custom among some when

pronouncing echad to move the head slightly—right, left, forward, back, down and up—to indicate that the oneness of G-d permeates all directions of creation.

The Zohar mentions that when we pronounce the word echad, we should meditate on being willing to give up our life for G-d, even imagining ourselves being consumed by fire, thus sanctifying G-d's name.

Symbolically, when we cover our eyes, we are momentarily, technically blind, and as "the blind is akin to the dead," so the covering the eyes suggest a death of a sort—a rapture, a state of ecstasy, an expiration of the soul. In the words of Rabbi Eliezer Ezkari, it is as if "one died and is in front of the King."

In the opening statement of the Shema, plus the short statement that follows (Baruch Sheim), there are 49 letters, corresponding to the 49 gates of understanding, indicating that these passages of the Shema need to be absorbed intellectually, emotionally and ultimately factually.

 *It is customary to cover our eyes with our right hand while reciting the first verse, to promote deep concentration.*

17. Page 29 [141] שמע

Recite in Hebrew

 *The statement following the Shema "Baruch Shem..." is generally recited quietly. Only on Yom Kippur is it read aloud. We are taught that Moses originally heard this prayer from the angels when he was on Mount Sinai and brought it back down with him. He told the Israelites to say it quietly, because it was "stolen" from heaven. Thus we say it quietly all year round. But on Yom Kippur we are spiritually raised to the level of angels and we say the verse out loud and in public.*

18. Page 105 [141] ברוך שם

Recite in Hebrew

19. Page 108 [144] מי כמוך

Sing in Hebrew

 *This prayer is called the "Amidah" the "standing" prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.*

The Amidah is the central part of the service, it's said every day of the year. It's divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.

Praise: *The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.*

Petition: The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.

Thanksgiving: Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.

The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before G-d. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to G-d) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with G-d in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that G-dliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter G-d's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) loud and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.



Vidui – Confession

During the Amidah of Yom Kippur we recite a unique prayer called ‘al chet’. This is meant to be an intimate moment when we acknowledge our iniquities before G-d who knows “the mysteries of the universe and the hidden secrets of every human being.” The first essential step in teshuvah – repentance – is acknowledgement of the wrongdoing – the exact antithesis of denial. Repentance cannot be just a fleeting thought like other thoughts that come and go in a person’s mind. By acknowledging our sins in words, our repentance becomes much more real and help us reach the complete understanding that our sins are wrong and cannot be rationalized away.

We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

*Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.*

Sins in general are understood not as mere transgressions but as disconnections. When we sin we actually displace and disconnect ourselves from our own true self. As in is therefore not committed just against G-d, it is committed against the self as well. Teshuvah, which requires Viduy – confession – or acknowledgement, is the process of realigning and returning to our real self, our Divine soul.

In the Yom Kippur service, sins are expressed in the plural not only to save individuals from embarrassment but so that the congregation as a whole might attain true atonement. We cannot confess only for ourselves, rather we have to beg forgiveness for all Jews who sin. As the great 16th century Kabbalist, the Ari, said, “Confession is written in the plural, ‘we have sinned’ because all Israel is considered like one body and every person is a limb of that body. So we confess to all the sins of all the parts of our body.

Of course we should not feel limited to confess only the list of sins printed in the prayer book, we should also mention any specific sins which we may have committed.



Hashem Sifasai - A toddler, at first cannot walk, but quickly masters the art. A child fears water, but quickly learns to swim. Many of our limitations in life are more perceived than real.

In Hebrew the word for “lips” is the same for “river banks”. The banks of a river define its limitations. When we say “G-d open my lips” we are also saying “G-d help me to see beyond my perceived limitations”.

20. Amidah – A time for quiet reflection. G-d understands all languages.



Introduction prior to Musaf service where the chazzan expresses his unworthiness to represent the Congregation before G-d, yet beseeches Him to accept his prayers and those of the Congregation. Followed by Half Kaddish chanted in an ancient melody.

21. Page 116 [156] מסוד Recite in English



Zachreinu L'Chaim – During the recitation of the Amidah between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there are additions in the prayers.

This short addition called zahrienu or "remember us" contains the unholy number of eleven words signifying the eradication of forgetfulness. The holy number is ten, as in the Ten Sefirot (the ten spheres/channels of Divine energy through which G-d created the vessels of this world and which continue to permeate all existence).

In the holy (kedusha), there is a full integration of the Divine light within the vessels; however, in the unholy (kelipa), the Divine light does not fully permeate the vessel and remains detached and separate. Therefore, there are ten vessels plus the light, comprising the number eleven.

In the world of kedusha, which signifies full integration, there is no forgetfulness. In fact, there is no lapse of time, as all time is one unified whole. It is a world of no separation, and thus the past is as present as the future. It is only in the realm of kelipa, a world of separation and disunity, that the past becomes separate from the present and future, and there is forgetfulness.

Further on in Amidah, we continue with references to memory. Before "Who revives the dead," we add "Who is like You..." This short prayer contains eight words, as the number eight represents the transcendent—that which is above the natural cycle of created reality, represented by the number seven (as in the seven days of the week). Eight is beyond time. In recognition of this fact, the High Priest would also wear eight garments, thus unifying all time with the place of Divine mercy.

22. Page 117 [158] זכרנו Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English

23. Talking Point #2 [Break for מורה חטאים and אתה הוא]

A friend once related to me.... when my youngest daughter was three years old, she discovered the helium balloons in the flower section of our local supermarket, handed out free to every child who asks. I tied the string around her wrist so the precious balloon wouldn't escape up to the rafters. She bounced it on its string as I

pulled it this way and that to avoid bumping other shoppers. She hugged it as we climbed into the car for the ride home.

As I pulled into the driveway, my daughter flew out of the car, her balloon bobbing along behind her, raced in through the front door and out again to our back yard, slipped the string off her wrist and gazed upward as the balloon rose into the sky and slowly drifted away.

"Why did you let go of your balloon?" I asked, slightly miffed that she had so casually cast away the new toy she had been fussing over for the last half hour. My daughter just shrugged, giggled, and watched the balloon disappear from sight.

After our next trip to the market she did it again. Then again, over and over for months. Every time I asked the same question. "Why did you let go of your balloon?"

Finally I got an answer. My daughter looked me in the eye and replied, "It's a present for God." [continued]

24. Page 118 [160] אתה הוא *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*

25. ♪ Page 118 [160] אתה הוא TTO: Napoleon's March or האדרת והאמונה

 Moreh Chatoim - This lengthy and intricate piyut contains the double acrostic, Meshullam son of Rabbi Klonimos, may he be strong. He is the son of the one who recorded the prayer Unesane tokef. He was born in 950 CE in Lucca, Italy and died in 1020 in Mainz, Germany. He composed a number of the liturgical poetry used in the High Holiday services. It combines acknowledgement of G-d's greatness, expressions of Israel's age-old loyalty to Him, hopes for forgiveness, and expectations of Redemption and service in the Temple. Intertwined is yet another theme, Psalm 145, the Ashrei which has a special status. The Talmud teaches that one who recites this psalm properly 3 times a day is assured a share in the World to Come. Thus we combine this precious psalm with our pleas that G-d accept our repentance.

26. ♪ Page 118 [160] מורה חטאים TTO: אשרי – Camp (First 3)

27. Page 118 [160] אנא סלה *Recite in English*

28. Talking Point #3 [Continued from previous talking point]

She doesn't do it anymore. And part of me mourns for the pure, innocent faith that prompted a little girl to give up her toy as an offering to the Almighty.

For all our experience and the sophistication, for all our indulgent smiles at the simplicity of our children's beliefs, is it not likely that our children know something we don't, something they themselves soon won't know or even remember they once knew? And perhaps it is precisely their power of belief that sets them apart from the adults they will become.

Children believe in God, believe in their parents, believe in their country and their school and their friends and that good will always win out over evil. Their trust and faith haven't yet been sullied by the lies of politicians, the corruption of law and justice, the avarice of sports heroes, the superficiality of Hollywood or, most importantly, the cynicism of their parents, who may try for a time to put on an act to spare their children from their own disillusionment.

But what if it worked the other way, that we could learn an old lesson from our children instead of imposing yet another new lesson upon them? What if we could turn the clock back and recapture even a whiff of the innocence of youth? Would we reach out to grasp it, or have we grown too jaded even to try?

This Yom Kippur, Jews around the world will fill synagogues to commemorate the Jewish Day of Atonement. But Yom Kippur celebrates much more than Atonement and forgiveness. It celebrates birth and rebirth; it celebrates beginning and renewal, for it commemorates nothing less than the rejuvenation and purification of the world and Mankind.

Let us ask ourselves how we can turn back the clock, exchanging bad habits for new challenges, routine for renewal, and cynicism for enthusiasm. Instead of smiling with adult condescension at the innocence of children, let us consider instead that the difference between childhood and maturity is not whether we give presents to our Creator, but what kind of presents we choose to give. A child serves God by sending a balloon up into the sky. An adult serves God by releasing his spirit to soar to the heights of Godliness.

Have we given charity in proportion with our means? Have we visited the sick and comforted the distressed? Have we consistently spoken with kindness to our neighbors, with respect to our superiors, and with patience to our children? Have we honored the Sabbath and studied the ancient wisdom of our people?

It's not enough to make resolutions; we need to inspire ourselves to see them through. We need to awaken in ourselves an awe of the Almighty by reflecting upon the vastness of creation, the unfathomability of the stars in their courses, the mysteries of life, and the limitless potential of the soul -- to behold for a lingering moment the immeasurable beauty and majesty of our universe.

And if we can follow through, if we can make the moment last without slipping back into our well-traveled rut of discounting every noble and beautiful thought and deed, then perhaps we can retain our faith in those things truly worthy of faith throughout the coming year.

29. Page 120 [163] היום יכתב *Recite in English*

30. Page 120 [163] אמרו לא-להים TTO: אסדר לסעודתא (First 3)

☺ *A kind-hearted fellow was walking through Central Park in New York and was astonished to see an old man, fishing rod in hand, fishing over a beautiful bed of red roses.*

"Tsk Tsk!" said the passer-by to himself. "What a sad sight. That poor old man is fishing over a bed of flowers. I'll see if I can help." So the kind fellow walked up to the old man and asked, "What are you doing, my friend?"

"Fishin', sir."

"Fishin', eh. Well how would you like to come have a drink with me?"

The old man stood up, put his rod away and followed the kind stranger to the corner bar. He ordered a large glass of beer and a fine cigar.

His host, the kind fellow, felt good about helping the old man, and he asked, "Tell me, old friend, how many did you catch today?"

The old fellow took a long drag on the cigar, blew a careful smoke ring and replied, "You are the sixth today, sir!"

31. Talking Point #4 [Stop in middle for מעשה etc.]

Why So Many Blessings in the Prayers?

Long before many books were written on happiness, Judaism provided advice on how to achieve it – and it is not through working 14 hour days and ordering

breakfast, lunch and dinner on Seamless Web. The Talmud declares, “Chayav adam levarech me’ah b’rachot b’chol yom.”

A person ought to find 100 occasions a day for which to say a blessing. Indeed Jewish law requires us to actually recite 100 blessings a day!

When we awake in the morning, we give blessing for a new day, a fresh life that has been granted to us for another day. Before we put into our mouth a piece of food, before we take a drink, we make a blessing. Even when we come out of the bathroom there is a special blessing. Because Judaism believes that we must always celebrate life!

The Kuzari, a classical Jewish philosophy work explains that someone dead drunk can eat the best food and partake of the best drinks while listening to the most beautiful of music at the greatest art gallery -- and yet not enjoy it at all. They are too drunk. In life we are experiencing tremendous blessings but at times we are drunk with stress and responsibilities. The blessings remind us to be mindful of the rhythm of life, of the magic of our bodies and the miracle of creation. [continued]



Maaseh - The Hebrew word “maaseh” is an acronym for Melech Elyon Sar Haolam, Supreme King, Master of the Universe.

32. Page 123 [167] מעשה Recite in English

33. 🎵 Page 123 [167] מעשה TTO: חיילי אדוננו

34. 🎵 Page 123 [168] אשר אמץ TTO: א-לי אתה



Al Yisrael - This piyut follows the aleph beis in depicting G-d’s special relationship to Israel in all areas. In some verses the piyut describes how G-d gives something (majesty, purity, pleasantness) to Israel. In other, it describes how certain characteristics of the world (His Kingdom, His presence) depend upon Israel’s performance of the commandments.

43. 🗣️ Congregant: Page 124 [169] על ישראל אמונתו Recite in English



Hoaderes - Recited by the angels singing the praises of G-d. Meaning: all attributes that can be enumerated true and perfect only when applied to G-d, who is eternal and absolutely perfect. When applied to moral human being, they are not true since we have a limited life on earth and all his qualities are necessarily limited and imperfect. This should inspire a profound sense of humility.

35. Page 124 [170] האדרת *Sing in Hebrew*



This piyut arranged alphabetically praises the attributes of G-d as He sits in judgment and is filled with forgiveness, compassion and mercy.

36. Page 125 [170] לא-ל עורך *Recite in English*

37. 🎵 Page 123 [168] לא-ל עורך TTO: ירושלים של זהב

38. Page 125 [171] נקדישך *Recite in Hebrew*

39. Talking Point #5 [Continued from previous talking point]

In 1992, Britain's chief rabbi Jonathan Sacks received his first invitation to lunch at 10 Downing Street. Prime Minister John Major was hosting a lunch for the-then President of Israel, the late Chaim Herzog and 10 Downing Street phoned to ask whether Rabbi Sacks and his wife would like to come to luncheon. His office very enthusiastically said "Yes" and a very embarrassed voice on the other end of the line said "I suppose the Chief Rabbi would probably prefer a kosher meal" and the chief rabbi's office said "Yes, probably." He said he would organize this.

A few days later the same official phoned again and said, would the Chief Rabbi please be willing to say "grace" and his office said "Yes" and an equally embarrassed voice said "Could it please be a short grace"; and so the office said, "we'd organize this."

Anyway, all the organization was done and the great day came and Rabbi Sacks and his wife were ushered into a small dining room at 10 Downing Street. The Prime-Minister of England, with many of his cabinet members, the President of Israel and a couple of Israeli Cabinet Ministers were all there.

It was then that Sacks discovered that just when you think you've explained everything, there is one thing you haven't explained. What the rabbi hadn't explained is that before you can make a blessing in Judaism, you have to have something to make a blessing on. You have to take the bread in your hands and thank G-d for it; and he didn't realize that it is de rigeur in such circles to have a completely empty table in front of you.

At this point, as Rabbi Sacks realized this aghast, John Major stood up and said “and the Chief Rabbi will now say grace” and everyone stood up and turned expectantly toward Sacks.

“Consider the choice that I faced,” he later said. “Either I could say grace over nothing, thus taking the Lord’s name in vain and breaking the second of the Ten Commandments; or I could decline the invitation of the Prime Minister and thus set back fifty years of Anglo-Israeli relations!”

“As my eyes were lifted towards the hills whence salvation I hoped might come, out of the corner of my eye I caught sight of the one thing that saved the day. Somebody in 10 Downing Street, in a fit of aesthetic enthusiasm, had apparently decided that one of the gold table ornaments would look much better if it were draped with a bunch of grapes. It was the only edible item in the entire room and so I said a very general blessing that covered grapes and everything else, took a bite, and honor was satisfied.”

After the meal Sacks went up to John Major, and said “Prime Minister, you must realize that our faith is different from yours. In fact, you have much more faith than we do. You are prepared to thank the Lord for that which you are about to receive. We, from long historical experience, prefer to have received it first.

“You guys say Grace even on an empty table, because you trust – you have faith -- its coming. We Jews wait till it has actually been delivered!”



Penitential Prayers

Exclusive to Yom Kippur is an entire selection of penitential prayers which are recited in each of the five prayers (after the silent Amidah in the evening service, and in the cantor’s repetition in the other services). In the evening service the Ark is opened anew for each hymn, indicating opening a new dimension of the soul. Each hymn is followed by reciting the thirteen attributes of compassion – which were revealed to Moses atop Mt. Sinai before he descended on Yom Kippur. In total the Ark is opened five times corresponding to the five levels of the soul.

The penitential prayer in each of the five prayers consists of these special hymns:

Zachor Rachamecho – Remember your mercies (in Mussaf this is replaced with the Ten Martyrs – *eleh ezkera.*)

Zachor Lanu - Remember for us the covenant of the Patriarchs – Biblical quotations promising forgiveness.

Shema Koleinu – Hear our voice – heart-rending petitions to G-d imploring that he not reject us.



“Shema Kolaynu” (“Hear our voice”)

We repeat the next four lines responsively after the chazan.

Each line highlights our plea to G-d not to abandon us and to have mercy on us at this crucial time.

40. Page 130 [177] שמע קולנו Recite in Hebrew and English



“Ki Onu Amecha” We joyfully describe the unique closeness to G-d that we, as the Jewish nation, enjoy. It first lays out 12 aspects of the parallel relationship we have with G-d, and then 4 aspects of our sin and inadequacy, but G-d is merciful and infinite, therefore we confess our sins and seek His forgiveness.

41. 🎵 Page 130 [178] כי אנו עמך TTO: Nusach



“Oshamnu” (“We have transgressed”)

The next section follows the order of the Hebrew alphabet and forms a general confession. We lightly hit our chest with our right hand while saying each phrase in this paragraph.

42. 🎵 Page 131 [179] אשמנו TTO: Nusach

43. Page 132 [180] אתה יודע Recite in English



We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit

Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit

Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.

44. Talking Point #6

Yom Kippur, with all its holiness and awesomeness, will atone for most of our sins, but not all. There are many sins that Yom Kippur won't touch. Those are the sins that are between a person and his fellow man. Sins like gossip, slander, biting criticism, humiliation... you get the idea.

All of the effort you will put into your Yom Kippur repentance won't erase the gossip.

All the tears and fasting won't wipe out the hurtful words.

All the agonizing hours spent in shul pouring out your heart to God won't alleviate the damage done to another's feelings.

Atonement for these sins can only be gained by requesting forgiveness from those we have hurt. The reason is simple yet fundamental. We must understand that part of our relationship with God is the relationship between ourselves and our fellow Jews. The two are inseparable. The Torah doesn't allow for the railroading and trampling of individuals, notwithstanding any so called lofty goals.

The Talmud tells us that one of the questions the Angel of Death asks at the moment of death is, "Did you treat your friend royally?" He doesn't use the terminology, "Did you allow your friend to co-exist with you." No, he uses the words "treat your friend royally." This is because we are all princes and princesses in God's royal family and deserve to be treated as such.

Time to Get Over It

The following true story brings the lesson of Yom Kippur home in a most poignant way.

Shmulik was having a lousy morning. He just had a heated argument with his wife which he concluded by walking out and slamming the door of his home in one of small Israeli towns in the "West Bank." Rivka, his wife, was visibly hurt and pained.

Fifteen minutes later the phone rang. "Hi Rivka, its Shmulik. I'm heading into the tunnel and I just wanted to say that I love you and I'm so sorry for what happened before."

Why the sudden change of face?

In years past there have been numerous sniper attacks in or around the tunnel Shmulik was referring to. People started calling it the "Tunnel of Love" because when you enter the dreaded tunnel, you realize what's really important in life. It suddenly dawns upon you that there really isn't anything worth fighting over. Your fervent wish is to make it out alive and see your loved ones again, because after all is said and done nothing matters more than your relationships with the people in your life.

Yom Kippur is a tunnel of sorts. At this riveting moment we are begging and cajoling God for the gift of life and all its necessities. In return we promise to start making things right.

Well here's one place you can start.

Pick up the phone and call that person that you haven't been on speaking terms with. Ask forgiveness from those you have hurt and offended. Make up with your neighbor, ex-business associate or old classmate. Tell your mom, dad, brother, sister, spouse, kids or in-laws how much you love them and care about them. Because after all is said and done other things don't matter much.

Forgive with a full heart those who have mistreated you. Promise to call them after Yom Kippur to personally ask for forgiveness and have them in mind in your prayers.

May we all be blessed with the best year of our lives!

☺ *Dave told his doctor that he wasn't able to do all the things around the house that he used to do.*

When the examination was complete, he said, "Now, Doc, I can take it. Tell me in plain English what is wrong with me." "Well, in plain English," the doctor replied, "you're just lazy."

"Okay," said Dave. "Now give me the medical term so I can tell my wife."

45. Page 138 [189] אבינו *Recite in English*

46. Page 139 [190] ובספר *Recite in English*



Avinu Malkaynu is one of the most famous prayers of the Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur service. It was introduced by the great Talmudic sage, Rabbi Akivah almost 2000 years ago. At that time no other form of prayer was successful in relieving a devastating drought that gripped Israel. As soon as Rabbi Akivah used this formula to ask for rain, it immediately began to rain.

Since then, Avinu Malkaynu has occupied a very important place in our prayers. Reflects a dual relationship of intimacy and awe we have with Hashem. He is our King with complete control and absolute power over us. Yet he is also our Father, denoting the compassion, love, care and mercy He extends to us despite our errors of the past. This theme is central and integral to the High Holidays.

One of the ten melodies composed by the Alter Rebbe. The soulful melody, matching the earnestness of the text, is divided into three parts. The first, wordless, elevates the singers to a deeply spiritual mood. The second expresses yearning for the Divine, while the third is a declaration of faith in the help of our Father and King.

47. Page 139 [190] אבינו מלכנו Sing in Hebrew , first and last
[not recited on שבת]



Adonai, Adonai, - When Moses prayed to G-d to forgive the Children of Israel's sin of the Golden Calf, G-d in response revealed His thirteen attributes of mercy. In the Talmud we read that G-d appeared to Moses as a Chazzan in a Tallit and said, "whenever Israel sins, let them carry out this service before Me and I will forgive them."

48. Page 145 [198] ויהי Sing in Hebrew

49. Page 145 [198] ה' ה' Sing in Hebrew

50. Page 145 [198] רבונו Recite in English quietly



Beh Ana Rachitz, - These are the concluding lines of Brich Shmey, a prayer written in Aramaic, depicting G-d's mercy, praising him and extolling his goodness on behalf of the people of Israel. In the second century Rabbi Simeon stated that "when the Torah is removed to be read, the gates of mercy in heaven are opened and the attribute of G-d's love is stirred up."

51. Page 146 [199] בה אנא Sing in Hebrew

52. Page 146 [199] שמע Sing in Hebrew

53. Page 148 [202] קריאת התורה



The Torah reading describes the instructions to Moses and Aaron concerning the procedure of the Kohen Gadol's Temple service on the day of Yom Kippur. Much of this will be discussed in much greater detail during the Musaf service. This service enables the Jewish people to achieve atonement. It also discusses the laws of Yom Kippur.

In the **first** aliyah the story continues from where Aharon's sons just passed away by doing a service in the Mishkan without authorization. G-d here warns Aharon not to approach the ark at the wrong times, and tells him specifically to only approach it on Yom Kippur. On Yom Kippur is the appropriate time to get as close as Nadav and Avihu, as we too are "at-one" with Hashem. The Zohar teaches that the memory of their deaths takes the place of the Yom Kippur sacrifices.

The [shabbos second] aliya [also] gives further details of the Yom Kippur service regarding Aharon's changes of clothes and all the times he immerses in the mikvah between each change of

clothes, and the animals used in the sin offerings. This is for himself and his household. The immersion between cloth changes symbolizes elevating from one level to the next, not incrementally but with a quantum leap as the immersion (bittul) totally leaves behind the past as we start a new future on a higher level.

The [**second**/shabbos third] aliyah continues the description of Aharon's duties for the service in the Mishkan on Yom Kippur. Specifically included here is the scape-goat ceremony of casting lots over which goat would be the offering to Hashem and which would be cast off a cliff called Azazel as the “scape-goat”. Here Aaron also confesses over the sin offering on behalf of all the Kohanim.

In the **third** [shabbos fourth] aliyah, discusses the beginning of the incense offering and the bull offering. It also contains the verses the G-d shall bring atonement upon the Children of Israel, even for their willful sins, as the Tent of Meeting, i.e. the Divine Presence, dwells with them amid their contamination. Hashem is ALWAYS with us every step of the way, even when we err. This is an obligation on our part not to “shlep” Hashem into our impurities by living a proper Torah life.

In the **fourth** [shabbos fifth] aliya Aaron the High Priest confesses all of the sins of the Children of Israel after which he leans with both hands upon the head of the living goat that is to be sent into the desert. After he would change back into his golden vestments, he would leave his white linen vestments permanently in the Sanctuary, never to be used again. New ones were made every Yom Kippur. The Rebbe explains that if one wishes to be involved with the “inside service” of bringing another Jew closer to Judaism, by arousing in him an inner desire to return to G-d and help him atone for his sins, then one must first remove one’s metaphorical gold garments which are “for honor and for glory,” and adopt the attitude of selfless dedication, symbolized by the ordinary priest’s garments of plain, white linen.

In the **fifth** [shabbos sixth] aliya Aaron burns the fat of the sin-offering which symbolizes our enthusiasm and excitement associated with sin. G-d also states that Yom Kippur shall be on the tenth day of the month of Tishrei. This is also the day that Moshe rabenu came down from Mount Sinai with the second set of luchos (tablets) and informed the people that they had received atonement for the making of the golden calf. It is a Chassidic principal that we don't celebrate Jewish holidays only to commemorate historical events, but the spiritual revelation that happened to cause the original event happens again, every year on the same Hebrew date. Thus, the prototype Day of Atonement was when G-d forgave the Jewish nation for the making of the golden calf, and the same potential for atonement is repeated every tenth of Tishrei thereafter.

The sixth [shabbos seventh] aliya states that on Yom Kippur work shouldn't be performed, just like on Shabbos and that we should afflict our souls. The oral law defines afflicting one's soul as abstaining from eating, washing, anointing, wearing leather shoes, and marital intimacy. We are also told that this Yom Kippur service must be performed only by descendants of Aaron as Kohen Gadol and not by ordinary Kohanim.

HAFTORAH: After the Prophet Isaiah gives the Jewish people hope, he then urges them to return to G-d through good deeds, kindness and sincere teshuvah. Fasting alone is not enough without the spirit of devotion and return. It requires an emotional and spiritual vitality.

- 54. Prayers for the USA and Israel
- 55. Moment of Silence for victims of Terror
- 56. Yom Kippur Day Sermon
- 57. Talking Point #7 – Explanation of Yizkor

After the destruction of the Temple in Jerusalem, a custom developed to raise the memory of our lofty ancestors so that their merit should stand by us now and for our offspring in the future.

Every holiday when the Torah portion speaks of offering charity (tzedakah), those who no longer have parents say Yizkor and resolve to offer tzedakah in the memory of their beloved ones.

Yom Kippur is known in Hebrew as Yom Kippurim, the plural form indicating that it is a day of spiritual atonement both for the living and for those that have passed on. Thus on Yom Kippur, we also invoke the memory of our ancestors for a dual purpose: 1) that we can be sustained because of their holy memory, and 2) that through our positive actions, we inspire an elevation of their souls if such might be needed above.

Everything that exists on a physical level corresponds to what exists on the spiritual level—physical is a reflection of the meta-physical. When two people are related on a physical plane it is because they share the same root in the source of souls in a supernal sphere.

This means that although our actions can impact the entire world, those that are most affected by what we do are the souls most closely connected to our own soul. Thus, when children in this world give charity in honor and merit of their departed

parents, this action can affect the ascension of the parents' souls above.

In our world, there are choices; in the next world, there are only the effects. Free choice, the power to elect a new reality, to forge a new content/context, exists only in this manifestation. Since this is so, only in our world can people truly grow, expand and develop. There is always room for change and space to leap into new and unexplored realities. For this reason, any movement in the world of souls is dependent on the actions we take or actions we refrain from taking in this life. What level of integration our soul has with its source, or with what measure of intensity the personal light of our soul merges with the source of light, is contingent on what we do and refrain from doing in our present life.

This is so because the physical world below is founded on *chesed* ("loving-kindness"), and in the world of *chesed*, there are always second chances. This is not so in the spiritual world above, which is founded on *gevurah/din* ("strict justice"). There, everything is absolute and unconditional.

And yet, since our souls are closely rooted in the world above with our ancestors' souls, our actions below can and do stir movement above. When we do something noble in the memory of our loved ones, not only are we ennobling ourselves, but we are essentially causing an elevation of their souls, an elevation that would otherwise not be available for them.

We fill their void, allowing for their soul's ascent into the upper worlds, and by doing so fill the emptiness and void that their passing has left us. Yet, repeating the words of *Yizkor* alone is not sufficient. We need to be totally committed with strong resolve to do good, give to charity—in their name and for their benefit—and then certainly, the effects will be felt by them spiritually and by us spiritually, mentally and even physically.

At *Yizkor* it is customary to make pledges for *tzedakah*, and appeals are made for the synagogue or noteworthy Torah institutions.

A story is told of a man who complained about chest pains. His wife told him to lie down to rest and she would call the doctor. The doctor came to the patient's home, sat down at the bedside and took the patient's hand in order to take his pulse. In a faint voice the patient said, "Doctor, it is not my hand. The pains are in my chest, near my heart." To which the doctor responded, "I know, but from the hand we know how the heart works."

There is no doubt that everyone has a good heart, but let our hand demonstrate how our heart works.

58. Page 154 [210] יזכור *Recite in Hebrew and English*

59. Yizkor in memory of the קדושים

Yom Kippur Mussaf



Our souls are comprised of five spiritual levels. During the weekday, we access the three lower levels in our prayers. On Shabbat and holidays we access the fourth level. But it is only on Yom Kippur that it is possible for us to access the fifth, highest level – Yechidah – oneness with G-d, and only during Neilah, the final prayer service of the holiday.

The additional service – Mussaf – corresponds to the third level of the soul – Neshama (soul) – which relates to our intellectual life.



Introduction prior to Musaf service where the chazzan expresses his unworthiness to represent the Congregation before G-d, yet beseeches Him to accept his prayers and those of the Congregation. Followed by Half Kaddish chanted in an ancient melody.

1. Page 156 [213] הַנְּנִי Review Silently



Yodaiti - The cantor begins the repetition with this prayer asking permission of the Almighty to represent the congregation and to beseech him on our behalf. This is a serious undertaking and the Chazzan begs G-d to accept his prayer, if not for his sake but for the righteousness of those he represents.

2. Page 156 [214] יְדַעְתִּי Recite in English



Vidui – Confession

During the Amidah of Yom Kippur we recite a unique prayer called ‘al chet’. This is meant to be an intimate moment when we acknowledge our iniquities before G-d who knows “the mysteries of the universe and the hidden secrets of every human being.” The first essential step in teshuvah – repentance – is acknowledgement of the wrongdoing – the exact antithesis of denial. Repentance cannot be just a fleeting thought like other thoughts that come and go in a person’s mind. By acknowledging our sins in words, our repentance becomes much more real and help us reach the complete understanding that our sins are wrong and cannot be rationalized away.

We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.

Sins in general are understood not as mere transgressions but as disconnections. When we sin we actually displace and disconnect ourselves from our own true self. As in is therefore not

committed just against G-d, it is committed against the self as well. Teshuvah, which requires Viduy – confession – or acknowledgement, is the process of realigning and returning to our real self, our Divine soul.

In the Yom Kippur service, sins are expressed in the plural not only to save individuals from embarrassment but so that the congregation as a whole might attain true atonement. We cannot confess only for ourselves, rather we have to beg forgiveness for all Jews who sin. As the great 16th century Kabbalist, the Ari, said, “Confession is written in the plural, ‘we have sinned’ because all Israel is considered like one body and every person is a limb of that body. So we confess to all the sins of all the parts of our body.

Of course we should not feel limited to confess only the list of sins printed in the prayer book, we should also mention any specific sins which we may have committed.



The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before G-d. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to G-d) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with G-d in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that G-dliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter G-d's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.



Hashem Sifasai - A toddler, at first cannot walk, but quickly masters the art. A child fears water, but quickly learns to swim. Many of our limitations in life are more perceived than real.

In Hebrew the word for “lips” is the same for “river banks”. The banks of a river define its limitations. When we say “G-d open my lips” we are also saying “G-d help me to see beyond my perceived limitations”.

3. Amidah – A time for quiet reflection. G-d understands all languages.



Repetition of the Amidah – Remember us for life, King who desires life; inscribe us in the book of life, for our sake, O living G-d – four types of life. The word life is mentioned four times, corresponding to the four letters in G-d's most holy name, Yud, Hei, Vav and Hei. Additionally, these four repetitions of life correspond to the four spiritual worlds known as Atzilus (world of closeness), Briah (world of creation), Yezirah (world of formation) and Asiyah (world of action). Another four corrections are: this world, the world to come, the days of Moshiach and the resurrection of the dead. – Siddur HaRid

4. Page 165 [227] מסוד *Recite in English*

5. Page 165 [227] זכרנו *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*



Zachreinu L'Chaim – During the recitation of the Amidah between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there are additions in the prayers.

This short addition called zahrienu or “remember us” contains the unholy number of eleven words signifying the eradication of forgetfulness. The holy number is ten, as in the Ten Sefirot (the ten spheres/channels of Divine energy through which G-d created the vessels of this world and which continue to permeate all existence).

In the holy (kedusha), there is a full integration of the Divine light within the vessels; however, in the unholy (kelipa), the Divine light does not fully permeate the vessel and remains detached and separate. Therefore, there are ten vessels plus the light, comprising the number eleven.

In the world of kedusha, which signifies full integration, there is no forgetfulness. In fact, there is no lapse of time, as all time is one unified whole. It is a world of no separation, and thus the past is as present as the future. It is only in the realm of kelipa, a world of separation and disunity, that the past becomes separate from the present and future, and there is forgetfulness.

Further on in Amidah, we continue with references to memory. Before "Who revives the dead," we add "Who is like You..." This short prayer contains eight words, as the number eight represents the transcendent—that which is above the natural cycle of created reality, represented by the number seven (as in the seven days of the week). Eight is beyond time. In recognition of this fact, the High Priest would also wear eight garments, thus unifying all time with the place of Divine mercy.

 *Yom Miyamim - This piyut discussing the distinguished nature of the day of Yom Kippur was composed by R' Elazar HaKalir, who lived in the time of the Mishna, 2nd century CE. The word Kalir means cake or cooking and according to the Aruch, he became wise as a result of eating a cake upon which certain Kabbalistic formulas had been inscribed.*

6. Page 165 [228] יום מימים *Recite in English*
7. 🎵 Page 166 [230] אשא דעי TTO: מארמא אדמורא or אשרי - Camp
8. 🎵 Page 168 [233] אמרו לא-להים TTO: אזמר בשבחין
9. 🎵 Page 169 [235] מעשה א-להינו TTO: שיבנה

 *Asher Eimosecho - The theme of this piyut is to accentuate G-d's humility and mercy. Although G-d is dreaded and praised by the angels, He nevertheless desires the praise and loyalty of lowly human beings. It follows a double alphabetical sequence and alternates between depictions of the lofty majesty of the angels and the puny frailty of human beings.*

10. 🎵 Page 170 [236] אשר אימתך TTO: א-לי אתה (First 3)
11. 🎵 Page 170 [236] אשר אימתך *Recite in English (First 3)*

 *The moving prayer of "Unesaneh Tokef" is traditionally attributed to Rabbi Amnon of Mainz, Germany who some 800 years ago suffered tremendous torture at the hands of the Duke of Hessen for staying true to Judaism. As he lay dying, with his final breaths, he composed this prayer and recited it with his congregation on the first day of Rosh Hashanah. Three days later he came to Rabbi Kalonymos ben Meshullam in a dream, taught him the words to the prayer and*

requested that he send it to all of Jewry and that it be inserted into the Rosh Hashanah liturgy. Rabbi Amnon's wish was carried out and soon it was also included in the Yom Kippur prayers as well.

The prayer portrays G-d as the Shepherd of His flock, counting and examining each sheep one by one as it passes under His rod. So does He reviews the flock of humanity one by one, determining each individual's fate for the coming year.

But an individual human being is not merely a helpless sheep! Rather, he or she can influence their verdict by altering their behaviour towards G-d and man, specifically in the areas of sincere Repentance, Prayer from the heart, and Charity given with a cheerful spirit.

- 12. Page 171 [238] ונתנה תוקף *Recite in English*
- 13. 🎵 Page 171 [238] כבקרת TTO: Oh Gan Yisroel
- 14. Page 171 [238] ותשובה ותפלה וצדקה *Recite in Hebrew and English*
- 15. Page 172 [239] כתר *Sing in Hebrew*

📖 *Vchol Maaminim – Who grasps in hand the attribute of justice - G-d grasps judgment to prevent it from overwhelming man. Thus, if man is guilty in his judgment but is inclined to repent, G-d will restrain the punishment.*

- 16. Page 173 [241] וכל מאמינים *Sing in Hebrew*
- 17. 🎵 Page 173 [241] וכל מאמינים TTO: Nusach
- 18. Talking Point #1

Swiftly Answered Prayers

It is an article of both faith and wit to believe that G-d answers everyone's prayers: Sometimes, however, the answer is No.

Similarly, we should also look at the other possibilities. Sometimes the answer is Wait. And, occasionally, it is yes – right away!

Such is the case with one petitioner in the Torah, Eliezer. Eliezer is sent by Abraham to find a wife for Isaac. Arriving in Aram Naharayim, Eliezer stops by a well and prays. He knows that women come to the well every day. He anticipates

that one of them will be right for Isaac, and that he will encourage her to return with him. All he asks is that she offer to draw water for him and his camels.

And then, before he is finished his prayer – before! – this beautiful woman, Rebecca, appears. She lowers her bucket. She offers to draw water for Eliezer, and for his camels. And, of course, she eventually does become Isaac's wife.

What a happy ending! What a piece of luck!

But, as always, luck had nothing to do with it. The Sages tell us that it is our closeness to G-d at the time of our prayer that determines how soon the prayer will be answered. It's not that prayer takes time to reach His ears: It's fairly certain that prayer travels at least as fast as light, and is heard immediately.

There are three examples that the Kabbalah gives of prayers that were answered immediately: When Moses was under assault from Korach, and the earth split and swallowed up Korach and his rebels; when Solomon prayed for the Divine Presence to grace the Holy Temple in Jerusalem; and when Eliezer sought a bride for Isaac.

These three represent the three aspects of G-dliness being united with creation: Within the world (Moses), within man (Eliezer) and within Torah (Solomon).

In all of these instances the petitioners were not asking anything for themselves, but that the presence of G-d reveal itself to complete a cycle that the L-rd Himself had set in motion. To vanquish our foes. To bring Divine revelation. To honor His covenant with Abraham.

And so, if you feel your prayers are not getting through, don't question G-d's attitude toward you. Question, rather, your attitude toward the content of your prayer.

☺ *Abe has had a tremendous year selling life assurance policies and is asked by one of his colleagues for the secret to his success. Abe replies, "After I outline the benefits of life assurance, I go into costs. If the prospect then seems to be undecided, I say to him, 'OK, I understand that you might need some time to think it over, so why don't you sleep on it. Then let me know what you think tomorrow morning - IF you wake up, that is.'"*

20. 🎵 Page 170 [236] עלינו\כורעים TTO: Nusach

21. Page 177 [246] אוחילה *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*



Before beginning the Avodah section, the chazzan expresses his personal plea that G-d assist him in expressing the prayer as well as possible.

Even though the text is prescribed and the chazzan does not add any words of his own, dry words without inner feeling or comprehension are far less effective than a prayer chanted with feeling and understanding, thus he asks for G-d's assistance.



“Avodah”

We now begin the Avodah, the longest section of the Yom Kippur musaf. You may be seated at this time.

Please read along in the English, at your own pace. Whenever we say a paragraph together, you can pause and join us and then continue at your own pace from where you left off.

In the days of our Temple in Jerusalem, Yom Kippur was characterized by a series of special services that the Kohen Gadol, the High Priest would administer. What follows is chronicle of those events.

We begin by reading that G-d selected certain individuals throughout history to perform holy duties in His Temple. This lineage passed through Aharon, brother of Moshe, father of the scion of kohanim priests.

Before engaging in the special Yom Kippur procedures, the Kohen Gadol (High Priest) had to spend a week in spiritual preparation and purity.



This prayer is the story of history, of our lives, our fall and rise, of loss and hope, of death and rebirth.

The detailed account is quite moving and awesome how the High Priest prepared himself, with a full escort of assistants, for the sacred service: many immersions in the holy waters of the mikvah and 7 days of preparation. His service was both physically and mentally exhausting as it required both physical dexterity (while fasting and having no sleep Yom Kippur night) and total mental concentration, for a mis-thought could invalidate the entire service.

22. Page 178 [246] אתה כוננת *Review Silently*

23. Talking Point #2 (Possibly have a member of the congregation read this)

I would like to take a few moments and read for you a contemporary account of what we are now going to read in the avodah services and what took place in Jerusalem on Yom Kippur. (Either read yourself, or have a member of the congregation read this out loud)

Toward the end of the period of the Second Temple, a man named Marcus, a delegate of the Roman Empire who resided in Jerusalem, sent the following report of his experience in watching the Kohen Gadol enter and leave the Sanctuary on Yom Kippur. He wrote:

Seven days before that special day which is called Kippur and is the most important of all of their holidays, special seats are prepared in the home of the Kohen Gadol for the head of the court, for the Nasi, for the Kohen Gadol and his assistant, and for the King. In addition, seventy silver seats are set for the members of the Sanhedrin.

The eldest of the kohanim stands up and offers words of admonishment to the Kohen Gadol, telling him: "Know before Whom you enter, and remember that if you fail to have proper intent, you will Immediately fail and die and Israel's atonement will be lost. The eyes of all Israel are upon you. Examine your ways for perhaps you are guilty of iniquity - even slight - and there are sins that outweigh many mitzvos and only G-d knows their ultimate value. Examine your fellow kohanim and purify them. Be aware that you approach the King of all kings who sits on the throne of judgment and sees all.

The Kohen Gadol then responds and declares that he has already searched his heart; and repented of all those sins that he might have transgressed. He also declares that he has assembled his fellow kohanim in the Sanctuary courtyard and has bound them by oath In the name of the One Who causes His Name to dwell in the Sanctuary, that they admit all sins that they are guilty of or that they know concerning their colleagues. He then offers each and every one of them a proper means to repent. The King speaks to the Kohen Gadol encouragingly, offering him honor when he emerges from the Sanctuary.

The assembled then announce that the Kohen Gadol is about to depart from his home to his chamber in the Sanctuary, whereupon all the people came out to accompany him. And this is what I saw: First were all whose lineage was traceable to the kings of Israel [the Hasmoneans who were related to the Kohen Gadol.] They were followed by descendants of the house of David, with a man proclaiming before them, 'Give honor to the House of David.' They were followed by the

Levites, with a proclamation: “Give honor to the House of Levi.” There were thirty-six thousand Levites wearing blue silk. They were followed by the kohanim. They were followed by the singers and by the musicians (i.e., the Levites who performed these functions In the Temple, followed by the trumpeters, the gate-keepers, the incense makers, those who wove the curtains, the guards, those in charge of the storehouses, and those who performed various work in the sanctuary.

They were followed by the seventy members of the Sanhedrin followed by one hundred kohanim bearing silver staffs which they used to clear a path. Then came the Kohen Gadol himself followed by the elders among the kohanim, who walked in pairs.

The heads of the academies stood in the doorways and when the Kohen Gadol passed, they said: ‘Our master, the Kohen Gadol may your coming be in peace! Pray to our Creator that He give us lift so that we might occupy ourselves in His Torah.”

When the procession reached the entrance to the Temple Mount, a prayer was offered for the continuation of the House of David, followed by prayers for the kohanim and for the Sanctuary itself. The resounding ‘Amen” pronounced by the assembled multitude was so loud that the birds that flew overhead fell to the ground. The Kohen Gadol then bowed before the assembled and turned aside weeping in awe. Two deputy kohanim would accompany the Kohen Gadol to his quarters. There he took leave of his fellow kohanim.

All of this transpired when he entered the Sanctuary; but when he emerged, the honor accorded him was twice as great. The entire populace of Jerusalem would pass in front of him, many carrying torches of white wax, and wearing white clothing, while all the windows were decorated and filled with light.

The kohanim told me that many a year, the Kohen Gadol was unable to return to his own home before midnight because of the great crowds who sought to pass before him. Though they were all fasting, they would not return to their own homes before trying to have the opportunity to approach the Kohen Gadol and kiss his hand.

The next day, the Kohen Gadol held a great banquet, inviting his friends and relatives to celebrate his safe emergence from the sanctuary. He then commissioned a goldsmith to fashion a gold tablet on which was inscribed the following: I, so-and-so, the Kohen Gadol, served as Kohen Gadol in the great and

holy house serving the One who has rested His name in that place, in the year so-and-so from creation. May He who granted me the merit of this service, grant my children the merit to serve G-d after me.

☺ *A Jew walks into the bakery and orders a bagel. The man behind the counter says: "A bagel? That's 20 dollars." "20 dollars?! Are you mad!?" "Well, its 1 dollar for the bagel, and 19 dollars for Israel." "Fine. Money for Israel? How can I say no?"*

The next day the same guy comes in to the bakery, and orders a challah. The man behind the counter says: "Challah? That's 40 dollars." "Are you insane?!" "Sir, its 5 dollars for the challah and 35 dollars for Israel." The man shrugs his shoulders but he pays the money.

The third day, he comes in and orders a cheesecake. "Cheesecake? 70 dollars." "What?! This is absolutely crazy." "Sir, 10 dollars for the cheesecake, and 60 dollars for Israel." At this point he had had enough. "You are completely mad! This is absolutely absurd and unethical."

"Sorry sir, I am just following the rules." "I demand to speak to the owner of the store!"

So the clerk goes to the door and calls out: "Hey Israel! Someone wants to talk to you!"



“Vehakohanim” (“And when the kohanim”)

The highlight of the service is the entry of the High Priest all dressed in white into the Holy of Holies, preceded by his pronouncing aloud G-d’s Ineffable Four-Letter Name (sheim hamefurash) as it is spelled. The first time is to address G-d. The second time he is appealing that G-d use this Name that represents mercy to grant forgiveness on this Yom Kippur day.

He would pronounce the Holy Name 10 times on Yom Kippur: 3 times at each of his 3 confessions and one time when he drew lots to which goat would become the sin-offering. Each time he pronounced the Holy Name, everyone who heard it would respond with Baruch Shem, Blessed is the name.

The Kohen Gadol recited this confession three times: once for his own sins and his household (Page 180[249]), second for the Kohanim (page 181 [250]) and lastly for the sins of the entire nation (page 184 [254]).

At that time, the entire assembly would prostrate themselves before G-d.

This was done as a sign of submission to Hashem.

We recall this custom, by bowing to the ground during this paragraph: at the words “hoyu korim” “they would bend their knees”, we kneel and at the words “umishtachavim” “bow down”, we bow. At the phrase “venoiflim al p’nayhem” “and fall on their faces”, we touch our foreheads to the ground and complete the paragraph in that position.

Women may simply bow their heads [and not prostrate themselves for reasons of modesty].

It was the celebration of an experience unmatched any other time of the year. On the holiest day of the year, in the holiest place on earth, the holiest man on the planet, utter the holiest word in the universe. This sacred experience is recreated every Yom Kippur at this time in the service where the entire psyche of spirit is involved.

- 24. 🗨 Page 185[256] אחר כלותו *Recite in English*
- 25. Page 185[256] יהי רצון/אשרי *Recite in English*
- 26. Page 186 [257] ובכן *Recite in English*

📖 *In this alphabetical poem, the Kohen Gadol is lauded in a series of similes, comparing him to various spiritual and material phenomena. The Kohen Gadol would not leave the Holy of Holies alive unless he performed the Yom Kippur service properly. Therefore, when he emerged unharmed from the Holy of Holies, there was ample reason to celebrate as this was testament to the atonement of the people of Israel after having experience the oneness of Space, Time and Person.*

- 27. Page 186 [257] כאהל *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*
- 28. 🎵 Page 186 [257] כאהל TTO: Nusach

📖 *Following this we describe, by contrast, the great tragedy of the destruction of the Temple. Yet we ask: "May the remembrance of these things bring us pardon?" Though, without a Temple, we cannot now recreate the actual Yom Kippur service, we thank G-d for helping us atone and we implore Him to recognize the deep void we experience.*

- 29. Page 187 [258] סליחות
- 30. Page 189 [262] אם תעינו *Recite in English*
- 31. Talking Point #3

"It All Depends On Me"

The highly descriptive phrase which characterizes the task before us on Yom Kippur is "cheshbon hanefesh" - "a spiritual accounting." On these sacred days each of us must evaluate his life honestly to eliminate all self-deception. To do this we must resist the temptation of creating alibis and flimsy excuses for our religious and moral failings. That this is a difficult task no one will deny, but we are truly capable of reaching this lofty goal.

This truth is illustrated by a powerful narrative related in the Gemara (Avodah Zarah 17a) concerning Elazer ben Durdaya, who strayed from the path of Jewish life, and became addicted to the allurements of lust and passion. One day when he was mocked by one who apparently shared his view of life, he was overwhelmed by his lowly moral situation, and realized that his life was being wasted. He felt an intense need to return to God.

In his earnest search for penance and in deep anguish of conscience, Elazer ben Durdaya sought external help, and he called out, "Mountains and hills, ask mercy for me."

"Ask mercy for you? We must ask mercy for ourselves."

"Heaven and earth, ask mercy for me."

"Ask mercy for you? We must ask for ourselves."

"Sun and moon, ask mercy for me."

"Ask mercy for you? We must ask mercy for ourselves."

"Stars and planets, ask mercy for me."

"Ask mercy for you? We must ask mercy for ourselves."

Elazer sat upon the ground, and after a long and serious period of probing introspection, he placed his head between his knees and expired while crying, "Ein hadavar talu ela bi" - "It all depends on me - the responsibility is totally mine!" A voice emerged from above and declared, "Elazer ben Durdaya is worthy of Eternal Life."

The explanation to this fascinating and enigmatic story may be the following:

Elazar ben Durdaya sought an easy way out of his personal dilemma. He tried to blame his corrupt life on external forces and not himself. First he appealed to the mountains and hills - symbolizing his parents (see Bamidbar 23:9, Rashi): "Declare it was not my fault. I was not disciplined; I was spoiled. You were too busy to take care of me and did not have the time or patience to supervise me properly." But his plea was rejected.

In further defense of his shortcomings, he turned to heaven and earth - symbol of the society in which he lived and the people with which he associated: "I could not have been anything else; my environment molded my total identity. Why am I to blame?" But even this plea was rejected.

When they refused to accept the blame, he further declared, "Sun and moon, help me." They are the symbol of affluence, as scripture says, "With the bounty of the sun's crops, and with the bounty of the moon's yield" (Devarim 33:13, Rashi). He cited the affluence of the society in which he had lived: "All I knew was material things; I was brought up in the 'good life.' I wanted pleasure; I was taught no other values. Was I to blame?" And this plea, too, was rejected.

Finally, his despair reaching an unbearable climax, he cried out to the stars and planets - symbol of a predestined fate of evil within him. He also blamed his problems on "the good luck alibi": "I did not have mazal. You tell them...I could not help living the way I did...tell them it was not my fault." Little did he realize that our sages have said, "Ein mazal l'Yisrael" - "The Jew is not controlled by mazal - the heavenly constellations - but ascends above it" (Shabbat 156a). Do not blame it on mazal - blame it on yourself!

When his final plea was rejected, Elazar ben Durdaya probed deeply into his heart and soul and then he found the truth: "There is no one external factor I can shift responsibility to. Ein hadavar talui ela bi - It all depends on me, I am totally responsible for my actions."

Now that we have described the repentance of Elazar ben Durdaya, one may rightfully wonder who was this personality? According to the Kabbalists (see Seder Hadorot) he was a reincarnation of Yochanan Kohen Gadol who served for eighty years as a High Priest in the second Beit Hamikdash and who became a heretic at the end of his life (Berachot 29a). Elazar ben Durdaya, with his brief realization and confession of truth, acquired the merits which Yochanan Kohen Gadol lost in one hour after eighty years of service of God, and in only one hour of sincere attachment to God the neshamah of Elazar ben Durdaya became worthy of eternal life.

There is, however, another beautiful and intriguing explanation given by Rabbi Yehudah Lowy, the famous Maharal of Prague. According to him there was no such person as Elazar ben Durdaya. It is a pseudonym. The word Elazar is a juxtaposition of two words "Keil ozeir" - "G-d helps" - and Durdaya, which in the language of the Talmud (Avodah Zara 32a) is the sediment which falls to the

bottom of the wine barrel. This episode is a metaphor to teach that Elazar "Keil ozer" - "G-d helps" - "durdaya" - "the one who is compared to sediment" - one who fell to the lowest ebb and is like the sediment which lost all its wine quality - when he realizes that " 'Ein hadavar talui ela bi' - 'It all depends on me' - and I am the one who has to express sincere remorse and make the effort to change."

When this incident was reported to Rabbi Yehudah the Prince, he used this unusual act of honest introspection and teshuvah as a text for a great moral lesson to his disciples: "There are those who obtain their world (Olam Haba) with many years of work, 'veyeish koneh olamo besha'ah achat' - 'and there are those who acquire their world in one hour' - in one brief instance of self realization and self transformation."

On this great Day of Atonement, may we be inspired to emulate the example of Elazar ben Durdaya - reject all rationalization for our failures and shortcomings and resolve that "we are responsible for our actions" and return wholeheartedly to God.



Although G-d treats people fairly, according to their behavior, we plead with Him now that He mercifully overlooks our misdeeds and failures. This is composed in a reverse alphabetical scheme as we recognized how we too have backtracked and slide back spiritually.



"Eileh Ezkorah" – These I will remember. We are about to read a moving part of the Mussaf service when we describe various troubles that have befallen us since the destruction of the Temple, ending with the heart-rending story of the "Ten Rabbinic Martyrs".

In one of the most moving accounts, we recount the story of the cruel Roman emperor who decreed that the ten greatest Jewish leaders of the time should be brutally put to death. Rabbi Yishmael, the high priest, purifies himself and with reverence pronounces G-d's ineffable name and ascends to the heavenly heights to inquire if this decree comes from G-d.

He ascends and inquires of the angel clothed in white, who answers him: "Take it upon yourselves, righteous, beloved Sages, for I have heard from behind the curtain that this decree has been imposed upon you."

The prayer continues with a graphic description of the savage executions of the ten great martyrs.

The angles cry out in bitter grief: Is this the Torah and such its reward?! A voice from heaven responds: This is my decree; submit to it.

The angles' resonation cry echoes through history – through all the deaths and persecutions we have endured. Their cry reverberates in our Yom Kippur prayers – prayers that continue to be said with tears that soak the very fibers of existence itself. Cries that have pierced the heavens, waiting for a response.

Yes, we have submitted to your decree. But we demand more. We appeal to you to end the pain, to end the bloodshed, to end all suffering.

On the holiest day of the year, in midst of the prayer of transcendence, immediately following the account of the pinnacle of all life experience – entering the Holy of Holies we do not forget that we live in a world of pain. And we demand a response.

No denial. No escape. Even at the height of our spiritual elevation, we remember our losses, and we implore of G-d to amend for them.

This is the ultimate transcendence.



It was during the morning Shema reading when R' Akiva was taken out to be murdered publicly. During his ordeal he accepted G-d's sovereignty upon himself by reciting the Shema joyously and oblivious to the pain. Turnus Rufus, the Roman commander who ordered the barbarous execution, was flabbergasted. 'Have you no feeling of pain that you can laugh in the face of such intense suffering!' he exclaimed. Even R' Akiva's own students wondered, 'Our teacher, even to this extent?'

The dying sage explained, 'All my life I was concerned over a phrase of the Torah to accept His sovereignty "with all your soul", this implies that one must serve G-d even if it means forfeiting one's life. I wondered if I would ever have the privilege of serving G-d to such a degree. Now that the chance has come to me, shall I not grasp it with joy?' He repeated the first verse of the Shema – Hear O Israel, the L-rd is our G-d, the L-rd is One.

A heavenly voice was heard saying, 'You are praiseworthy, R' Akiva, for your soul left you as you proclaimed G-d's Oneness! You are praiseworthy, R' Akiva, for you are ready to enter the life of the World to Come.'

Modern day mesirus nefesh – i.e. mesiras ha-ratzon.



The Ten Martyrs

Ayleh Ezkerah / These I Will Remember

In the words of Mark Twain, "The Egyptian, the Babylonian and the Persian rose, filled the planet with sound and splendor, then faded to dream stuff and passed away; the Greek and the Roman followed, and made a vast noise, and they are gone... All things are mortal but the Jew; all other forces pass, but he remains." And what about the French, the British and the Americans. How long until they too are relegated to the quiet halls of museum exhibitions visited only by curious strangers—and by Jews.

True, Am Yisroel Chai, the Jewish people live. And so do Rabbi Yishmael, Rabbi Akiva and the other martyrs. Their words have guided and inspired us for all of these centuries. But what's more, in a sense, they still speak to us. Everyday, countless students of the Talmud, of Jewish thought and wisdom, study their words in schools and yeshivot all over the world. Their words are alive, seriously reckoned with and hotly debated. We live because they live. But if they pass, what will become of us?

Triumph of the Spirit - A Look at some of the Martyrs

Rabbi Akiva

Rabbi Akiva is one of the most famous names in Jewish history. At the age of forty he was an illiterate shepherd who detested the rabbis of his day.

One day, Akiva noticed a rock that had a small, smooth hole bored through it. He soon noticed that the hole had been created by droplets of water that were dripping onto the rock. "If a drop of water can penetrate a stone," he thought, "then surely the words of Torah can penetrate my heart." This realization sparked a transformation that saw the ignorant Akiva grow into the great Rabbi Akiva, teacher of his nation.

In the end, Rabbi Akiva was tortured to death by the Romans for the crime of teaching Torah. The last words he uttered were, *Shema Yisroel...*

Rabbi Chananya ben Teradyon

Rabbi Chananya ben Teradyon was one of the preeminent sages of his day, yet more than anything he was known as a man with an overriding concern for the poor. His efforts to raise funds on their behalf are legendary.

In the end, he too became a victim of Roman savagery. Before they burned him at the stake, the Romans wrapped his body in a Torah scroll and packed tufts of water-soaked wool around his heart to delay his death and prolong the suffering.

Like Rabbi Akiva, Rabbi Chananya ben Teradyon in his final moments continued to embody the triumph of a noble soul. His final words to his disciples were, "I see the parchment burning, but the letters are flying to heaven."

Rabbi Yehudah ben Bava

Rabbi Yehudah ben Bava was fearless in his commitment to the continuity of Judaism, even in the face of the frenzied Roman drive to crush the Jewish spirit. In their attempt to vanquish the Jews, the Romans hunted down the sages of Israel and outlawed the ordination of new rabbis.

Rabbi Yehudah ben Bava ignored the threat of death that followed him everywhere. He did all he could to teach, inspire and ordain a new generation of rabbis. Our tradition says that when he was finally caught, the Roman spears turned his body into a sieve. But the new leaders he inspired lived on, as did the Jewish people.

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|-----|----------------|----------------------------|-------------------|
| 32. | Page 192 [266] | עשרה הרוגי | Review Silently |
| 33. | 🎵 | Page 193 [267] | טהר רבי ישמעאל |
| 34. | 🗣️ | Congregant: Page 193 [269] | פקידים נהרגו |
| | | | Recite in English |

Shema Kolaynu ("Hear our voice")

We repeat the next four lines responsively after the chazan.

Each line highlights our plea to G-d not to abandon us and to have mercy on us at this crucial time.

Our brains, our power, our art are all from G-d. Even when we decide—and it is our own decision—to do good and to restrain ourselves from the opposite, we are only playing our part in a cosmic script for which we were formed.

But we can call out to the Infinite Light and ask forgiveness. That is not in the script. When we do teshuvah—when we return to G-d—we return to a spiritual place where we unite with G-d's oneness.

So, when we cry out, "listen to our voice," perhaps we mean that G-d should disregard what we are saying, for our intention and focus might not be good, but simply listen to whom is speaking. This is the power of teshuvah, revealing the internal bond between our deepest selves and the Infinite Source of all light.

35. Page 195 [272] שמע קולנו Recite in Hebrew and English

36. Talking Point #4 [Break in middle]

Resting from our Job/Money/Appearance/ Status/Power & Revealing our True Identity.

RESTING FROM PHYSICALITY

On two separate occasions in the Torah, Yom Kippur is referred to as the Shabbos of Shabbos, the resting of rest, the being of pure being. The first time is Vayikra 16:31 where it states that, Shabbos Shabboson Hee lachem, “A total day of rest it (literally she) will be to you”. The second time is Vayikra 23:32 where it says, Shabbos Shabboson Hu lachem, “A total day of rest it (literally he) will be to you”.

We can learn from this subtle linguistic hint that there is both the feminine and the masculine quality to Yom Kippur. On a symbolic level, the feminine represents receptivity, whereas the masculine represents assertiveness. --This binary is by no means definitive or valiative, nor is it even gender based on a physical level. All men and women have varying degrees of masculine and feminine energies. The feminine reflects a passive mode of receiving (Divine Providence/Faith), whereas the masculine is the active function of giving (Freewill). On Yom Kippur there is a total melding of the two into one. On this holy day we move beyond duality and dichotomy, beyond the perceived separation of inspiration and perspiration.

On Shabbos we rest from ‘work’ in order to enjoy family, food, spirituality and intimacy. It is a special day where we are able to ‘elevate’ all of our actions and experiences, even the most physical, up to the realm of the spiritual. On Shabbos the act of eating, for example, becomes a spiritual experience — it has a totally

different quality than eating during the six days of the week. Externally oriented enjoyments become vehicles for spiritual experience.

But on Yom Kippur, the Shabbos of Shabbos, we take a 'rest' from this form of rest. Yom Kippur is to Shabbos what Shabbos is to the six days of the week. This is a day when we are shov'ess, "resting", from food, drink and any other bodily need, desire or enjoyment (Rambam). On Yom Kippur we 'rest' from even the 'elevating' or 'sweetening' of all of our normal 'human activities' — we 'separate' ourselves from them completely. [Continued]



Penitential Prayers

Exclusive to Yom Kippur is an entire selection of penitential prayers which are recited in each of the five prayers (after the silent Amidah in the evening service, and in the cantor's repetition in the other services). In the evening service the Ark is opened anew for each hymn, indicating opening a new dimension of the soul. Each hymn is followed by reciting the thirteen attributes of compassion – which were revealed to Moses atop Mt. Sinai before he descended on Yom Kippur. In total the Ark is opened five times corresponding to the five levels of the soul.

The penitential prayer in each of the five prayers consists of these special hymns:

Elah Ezkera – Remembering the Ten Martyrs (special for Mussaf)

Zachor Lanu – Remember for us the covenant of the Patriarchs – Biblical quotations promising forgiveness.

Shema Koleinu – Hear our voice – heart-rending petitions to G-d imploring that he not reject us.

60. Page 194 [270] זאת קראתנו *Recite in English*



"Shema Kolaynu" ("Hear our voice")

We repeat the next four lines responsively after the chazan.

Each line highlights our plea to G-d not to abandon us and to have mercy on us at this crucial time.

61. Page 195 [272] שמע קולנו *Recite in Hebrew and English*



"Ki Onu Amecha" We joyfully describe the unique closeness to G-d that we, as the Jewish nation, enjoy. It first lays out 12 aspects of the parallel relationship we have with G-d, and then 4 aspects of our sin and inadequacy, but G-d is merciful and infinite, therefore we confess our sins and seek His forgiveness.



"Oshamnu" ("We have transgressed") The next section follows the order of the Hebrew alphabet and forms a general confession. We lightly hit our chest with our right hand while saying each phrase in this paragraph.

44. Talking Point #5 [Continued from previous talking point]

FIVE LEVELS OF REST

Overall there are five aspects, or areas of life, that we need to rest from on Yom Kippur (Mishna Yuma, 8:1).

These are known as the five types of Inu Nefesh or ‘inflictions of the spirit’, that we endure on this day. This concept of Inu Nefesh can also be understood to mean that we are ‘making ourselves poor’ on these five levels of our being, as the word Inu is related to the word A’ni or ‘poor,’. This indicates that we are diminishing, or impoverishing, our lower/surface levels of self so that we can reveal, or enrich, the deeper/higher levels of self.

The five levels of diminished (external) selfhood are;

1. No eating or drinking
2. No wearing leather shoes
3. No bathing or washing
4. No anointing oneself with perfumes or lotions
5. No marital relations

The Maharil, R. Yaakov Levi (1365-1427), the great codifier of the European customs, writes that the five prohibitions of Yom Kippur correspond to the Five books of the Torah, the Five Senses, the five immersions of the Cohen Gadol, ‘High Priest’ on Yom Kippur and the five prayers that we pray on Yom Kippur.

The five prayers of Yom Kippur are:

- 1) Ma’ariv — evening prayers
- 2) Shachris — morning prayers
- 3) Musaf — added prayers
- 4) Mincha — afternoon prayers
- 5) Neilah — closing prayers

The Tur, R. Yaakov Ben Rabbeinu Asher (1270-1340), correlates the five types of prohibitions on Yom Kippur to the five names or levels of the soul:

- 1) Nefesh — Functional Self
- 2) Ruach — Emotional Self
- 3) Neshamah — Intellectual Self
- 4) Chaya — Spiritual Self
- 5) Yechidah — Transcendent Self

Through these five prohibitions, explains the Maharal, R. Yehuda Loew (1520 – 1609), we are resting from and transcending our five senses of physicality, our Gufniyus.

The Alter Rebbe, in Siddur Im Dach, writes that the five types of prohibitions correspond to the five levels of Gevuros or ‘restrictions’ of Malchus, ‘Kingdom’ or physical reality, that experience an elevation of Yom Kippur. [Continued]

62. Page 197 [275] על חטא *Recite in Hebrew*



We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

*Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.*

45. Talking Point #6 [Continued from previous talking point]

Let’s unpack this issue a bit further and explore these correlations on an even deeper level.

These prohibitions or ‘restings’ represent the nullification of the external factors of our lives that we tirelessly pursue and define ourselves by. For, it is only when we strip away these external aspects of self that the real Self can emerge.

There are five external aspects through which a person will most likely define him or herself by, they are:

- 1) Job
- 2) Money
- 3) Appearance
- 4) Status
- 5) Power

The first level of resting:

- 1) Job —

Many people define themselves by their job or profession. We become so associated with our work that we begin to identify it not as what we do, but in fact who we are. This is indicated by the way that many people introduce themselves, ex: “Hi my name is Jacob and I am a doctor”.

2) Money —

People also tend to define themselves by how much money they have in the bank account. The more money they have in their account the more confident they feel — the less money, the less confidence, etc. Often, people who are very wealthy feel entitled to have an opinion about everything, even things unrelated to their wealth.

3) Appearance —

Another way that people define themselves is by how they look. Many people are so identified with their external appearance that they are ceaselessly striving to manipulate their image through cosmetic surgery, clothes, dieting, and other forms of grooming. This reveals that their sense of self-worth is almost entirely dependent on their external appearance.

4) Status —

People also define themselves by their naturally born status or perceived ‘birthright’. Through their ancestral lineage or progeny they may feel entitled or privileged. This can also result in the opposite, for example people may also feel disenfranchised or ‘less than’ due to their ancestry or progeny.

5) Power —

People may also define themselves by their positions of perceived power or powerlessness. That is to say that they define themselves by how much influence they have over others. This could be influence in a company, a community, a culture, etc.

When it comes to Yom Kippur we are being given the gift of ‘rest’ from these external definitions and identifications. And through these ‘restings’ we are able to find out who we truly are underneath all of these external images.

One is finally able to ask: after I have let go of my job, my money, my appearance, my status, my power — what am I left with? Who am I without all this?

Imagine a day (and that day is Yom Kippur) when you are not judging or defining yourself by your job, your bank account, your looks, your status or your power — it’s just you. Who are you?

Often, many people focus their attention and vitality, almost entirely, towards the foods they eat, the work they do, the material possessions they have, their physical

intimacies, and all the more ‘external pleasures’ of life. On Yom Kippur, a person is stripped of all these externals and is left with the ultimate existential question: Ayeka? Where are You?

This Holy Day is a time to reclaim our priorities and to reaffirm what really matters in our lives.

☺ *A little Jewish grandmother gets on the crowded bus and discovers that she doesn't have correct change for the fare.*

The driver tries to be firm with her, but she places her hand delicately over her chest and murmurs "If you knew what I had, you'd be nicer to me." He caves in and lets her ride for free.

She tries to push her way down the crowded aisle but people won't move over for her. She finally places her hand delicately over her chest and murmurs, "If you knew what I had, you'd be nicer to me." The crowd parts like the Red Sea and lets her down the aisle.

She gets to the back of the bus where there are no seats and looks significantly at several people, none of whom take the hint and get up to offer her their seat. Once again she places her hand delicately over her chest and murmurs, "If you knew what I had, you'd be nicer to me." Several people jump up and insist that she sit down and ride in comfort.

A woman who had been watching all this leaned over and said to her, "I know this is none of my business, but just what is it that you've got, anyway?"

The little Jewish grandmother smiled and said-"chutzpah."

📖 *"...eradicate...groundless hatred, from us and from every member of Your Covenant." A prayer for real Ahavas Yisroel!*

37. Page 203 [284] ברכת כהנים

38. Page 204 [285] אדיר *Recite in English*

📖 *We are certain that Hashem has heard our prayers and granted us blessing for the year ahead.*

39. Page 204 [285] ובספר *Recite in English*

📖 *"Today may your strengthen us." This is based on G-d's promise (in Isaiah) that he would maintain Israel as His Chosen People and think of us always as his servants, the offspring of His*

beloved Patriarch. He assured the people that even in exile He would strengthen them with the right hand of his righteousness, an allusion to His Divine and unlimited mercy.

Therefore it is sung with great exuberance to a Simchas Torah melody attributed to the Lubavitcher Rebbe's father, Reb Levi Yitzchok Schneerson.

We say each line ahead of the chazan and answer Amen after the chazan says each line.

40. Page 205 [286] היום תאמצנו *Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English*

Yom Kippur Mincha

 All of the prayer books have the traditional Hebrew with a running English translation. G-d understands all languages.

We will announce page numbers so you know what page we are on. However that does not mean you have to keep turning the pages to keep up with the congregation. More important that keeping up with the congregation is that the prayers are meaningful to you. If a particular prayer speaks to you, spend time with it- meditating or reflecting on it. Prayer is a dialogue between you and G-d. Whatever page you are on is the right page.

The service may be different than what you are used to. Some of the prayers we will recite together in Hebrew, others in English. Some will be sung out loud. If you are familiar with the tune, sing along, otherwise listen and learn. Throughout the services I will be interjecting explanations, stories and insight. Feel free to ask questions and discuss them.

If you have a question, feel free to ask me, Rabbi Backman or my wife Shterna.

Our custom is to stand whenever the ark is open. If you feel that you cannot stand every time the ark is open, that is OK, you may remain seated.

If you are asked to open the ark, or if you have a card which requires opening the ark, please approach the ark and open the doors when the rabbi signals.

 Our souls are comprised of five spiritual levels. During the weekday, we access the three lower levels in our prayers. On Shabbat and holidays we access the fourth level. But it is only on Yom Kippur that it is possible for us to access the fifth, highest level – Yechidah – oneness with G-d, and only during Neilah, the final prayer service of the holiday.

The afternoon service – Mincha – corresponds to the fourth level of soul –Chaya (life) – which relates to our transcendental life. All the prayers of this service (and even those that were said last night and this morning) are now seen through the lens of Chaya.

 The Torah reading at Mincha Yom Kippur deals with forbidden sexual relationships, because it is such a great and common temptation. This teaches that even at the loftiest place of Yom Kippur, we must always be vigilant on the most basic levels. The cornerstone of morality is self-control over animal sensuality.

Another message is that no matter what deep spiritual transcendence you have attained, you should continue to search. The word “sin” (chet) comes from the root cheisaron – deficiency. A sin can also refer to an inadequacy that relative to your particular lofty level, it is considered deficient. When we reach great heights, then suddenly new, subtle deficiencies can emerge that we were unaware of earlier.

The **Haftorah** is the entire Book of Jonah which concludes with the 13 attributes of Compassions. The book discusses the power of teshuvah and how one cannot escape from G-d, as Jonah tried to do. The repentance of the people of Ninveh serves as an inspiration to us to repent, and shows us that teshuvah can overturn a Divine decree.

Kabbalistically, Jonah symbolizes the descent of the soul into this world. Water symbolizes Chaya and Yechida – the unconscious dimension of the soul (water) that descends into the conscious world (land) of nefesh, ruach, neshamah. It tries to deny its mission until the universe itself forces it to embrace its calling. Thrown into water – its unconscious source and into the belly of the whale (fish connected to its source) –it reconnects and regains its sense of purpose. It then goes and calls the world to teshuva, and reveals the highest levels of the 13 Attributes of Compassion.



Vidui – Confession

During the Amidah of Yom Kippur we recite a unique prayer called ‘al chet’. This is meant to be an intimate moment when we acknowledge our iniquities before G-d who knows “the mysteries of the universe and the hidden secrets of every human being.” The first essential step in teshuvah – repentance – is acknowledgement of the wrongdoing – the exact antithesis of denial. Repentance cannot be just a fleeting thought like other thoughts that come and go in a person’s mind. By acknowledging our sins in words, our repentance becomes much more real and help us reach the complete understanding that our sins are wrong and cannot be rationalized away.

We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

*Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.*

Sins in general are understood not as mere transgressions but as disconnections. When we sin we actually displace and disconnect ourselves from our own true self. As in is therefore not committed just against G-d, it is committed against the self as well. Teshuvah, which requires Viduy – confession – or acknowledgement, is the process of realigning and returning to our real self, our Divine soul.

In the Yom Kippur service, sins are expressed in the plural not only to save individuals from embarrassment but so that the congregation as a whole might attain true atonement. We cannot confess only for ourselves, rather we have to beg forgiveness for all Jews who sin. As the great 16th century Kabbalist, the Ari, said, “Confession is written in the plural, ‘we have sinned’ because all Israel is considered like one body and every person is a limb of that body. So we confess to all the sins of all the parts of our body.

Of course we should not feel limited to confess only the list of sins printed in the prayer book, we should also mention any specific sins which we may have committed.



This prayer is called the “Amidah” the “standing” prayer as it is recited standing. There is evidence in the Torah that the blessings in the Amidah date back to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, although the final form was arranged in Babylonia by the Rabbis of the Great Assembly.

The Amidah is the central part of the service, it’s said every day of the year. It’s divided into three sections, Praise, petition and thanksgiving.

Praise: *The first three blessings recognize the glory of G-d. We approach as children of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob, We come to G-d who is kind, supports the fallen and heals the sick.*

Petition: *The middle expresses the Holiness of the day. In it contains prayers that talk of his kingdom and the restoration of Jerusalem.*

Thanksgiving: *Having concluded our request, we close the Amidah with gratitude to G-d for everything he has and will give us.*

The origins of the Amidah prayer date back to the times of our forefathers—Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov. In fact, one of the reasons that this prayer is known as the Shmonei Esrei or "Eighteen Blessings"—all of which we recite during the weekdays but not on Shabbat or on the holidays—is to draw a parallel to the eighteen times our forefathers are mentioned together in the Torah. This prayer was composed in its final form more than two thousand years ago, in the time of Ezra, the Scribe, and the Men of the Great Assembly, although another blessing—the nineteenth—was added by Rabbi Gamliel the Second, some time after the destruction of the Temple by the Romans circa 70 CE.

While reciting this lofty prayer, we stand with our feet together as explained in the Talmud (in Tractate Berachos 10b). This suggests that we are like angels, whose feet are always together. (Yerushalmi Berachos 1:1) There is no more room for movement, as we are within the innermost chamber before G-d. We have arrived. Our feet are as if together, also signifying that we have completely surrendered our sense of separate self, and we are bonded with the Eternal. (Rashba ibid.) This transformation encompasses our entire being, and a total metamorphosis takes place, of our orientation to the right (to G-d) as well as of our orientation to the left (to the ego), both of which are now joined together, connecting with G-d in unison. (Mabit)

As our separate self is no longer expressed, this prayer is chanted quietly or whispered to oneself. In fact, this prayer is often called "the silent prayer."

The needs and wants expressed in this most elevated of prayers are not meant to be selfish, though they may be depending on the consciousness and spiritual development of the person praying. They are meant to arise from a deep understanding that G-dliness can be fully expressed in the elevation of the material world. This is not an end in itself, but rather a medium allowing for our maximum Divine mission to be fulfilled. (For example, we pray for health, because when we are healthy, we have a more fitting state of mind to facilitate our physical transformation, and the more strength we have, the better we can serve this end.)

Three steps backward

The early Kabbalists advised that before we begin the Amidah, we take three steps backward, and then three steps forward. And so, we do today.

This is done to enhance our concentration and stimulate greater focus. The movement forward indicates and symbolizes our entry into the Creator's innermost chamber. Thus we symbolically enter a sacred space in which we can, if we truly desire, encounter G-d's presence.

The number of steps is highly significant, as the three steps mimic the three steps Moshe took when he entered prayer, as he traveled past the three partitions—the darkness (choshech), the first cloud (anan) loud and the second cloud (arafel)—before he encountered the Divine.

Mentally, we should visualize ourselves moving into the Holy Land, with the first step, then into Yerushalayim with the second step, and into the Temple with the third step, thus standing on the threshold of the Holy of Holies.



Hashem Sifasai - A toddler, at first cannot walk, but quickly masters the art. A child fears water, but quickly learns to swim. Many of our limitations in life are more perceived than real.

In Hebrew the word for “lips” is the same for “river banks”. The banks of a river define its limitations. When we say “G-d open my lips” we are also saying “G-d help me to see beyond my perceived limitations”.

1. Amidah - A time for quiet reflection G-d understands all languages



Repetition of the Amidah – Remember us for life, King who desires life; inscribe us in the book of life, for our sake, O living G-d – four types of life. The word life is mentioned four times, corresponding to the four letters in G-d's most holy name, Yud, Hei, Vav and Hei. Additionally, these four repetitions of life correspond to the four spiritual worlds known as Atzilus (world of closeness), Briah (world of creation), Yezirah (world of formation) and Asiyah (world of action). Another four corrections are: this world, the world to come, the days of Moshiach and the resurrection of the dead. – Siddur HaRid

2. Page 229 [320] מסוד

Recite in English

3. Page 229 [320] זכרנו

Sing in Hebrew, Recite in English



Zachreinu L'Chaim – During the recitation of the Amidah between Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur, there are additions in the prayers.

This short addition called zahrienu or "remember us" contains the unholy number of eleven words signifying the eradication of forgetfulness. The holy number is ten, as in the Ten Sefirot (the ten spheres/channels of Divine energy through which G-d created the vessels of this world and which continue to permeate all existence).

In the holy (kedusha), there is a full integration of the Divine light within the vessels; however, in the unholy (kelipa), the Divine light does not fully permeate the vessel and remains detached and separate. Therefore, there are ten vessels plus the light, comprising the number eleven.

In the world of kedusha, which signifies full integration, there is no forgetfulness. In fact, there is no lapse of time, as all time is one unified whole. It is a world of no separation, and thus the past is as present as the future. It is only in the realm of kelipa, a world of separation and disunity, that the past becomes separate from the present and future, and there is forgetfulness.

Further on in Amidah, we continue with references to memory. Before "Who revives the dead," we add "Who is like You..." This short prayer contains eight words, as the number eight represents the transcendent—that which is above the natural cycle of created reality, represented by the number seven (as in the seven days of the week). Eight is beyond time. In recognition of this fact, the High Priest would also wear eight garments, thus unifying all time with the place of Divine mercy.

4. 🕯️ Congregant: Page 229 [320] איתן הכיר *Recite in English*

5. Page 230 [323] נקדישך *Recite in Hebrew*

6. Talking Point #1 [Break in middle]

Jonah was a prophet who lived in the first Temple period. His first mission was given to him by the most famous of first Temple prophets, Elijah -- he was to anoint Jehu as king in the year 705 BCE. His were stormy times; the Jewish people were trapped in a pattern of spiritual decline that ended with first the conquest and expulsion of the Ten Tribes by the Assyrians in 607 BCE, and finally with the destruction of Jerusalem, which was followed by 70 years of exile.

As a prophet, Jonah knew far better than we can imagine what the inevitable end would be if no transformation would take place.

After the failure of his second mission, to rebuke Jehu's successor, Jeroboam the second, he was given his final mission.

The mission that God gave him was one that he could not open his heart to accept. He was sent to the capital of Assyria, Nineveh, to urge its population to repent. How bizarre the assignment sounded to him! His own people were falling uncontrollably into a chasm that seemed to have no bottom, yet he was sent to save others -- the archenemies of Israel!

Jonah actually dreaded success of this mission far more than he dreaded failure. How could he bear to witness the contrast of the Assyrians returning to God in the

face of his prophecy, with the Jews stubbornly resisting any chance for spiritual self-preservation. Therefore, he attempted to escape from his destiny.

Jonah fled from Israel by ship to silence the voice of prophecy that can only be heard in the Holy Land. But a storm at sea forced him into the recognition that no one can escape from God. In the midst of calm waters, his boat was tossed in a tempest until it was on the verge of breaking. The sailors prayed to their gods. Jonah went to sleep.

He knew the truth. It was he who had already cut himself off from God; there was nothing to say and nothing to pray for.

His apathetic behavior aroused the curiosity of the sailors. He told them his story. He believed in God, yet he was running away from Him.

Knowing he was the cause of the storm, he implored the sailors to toss him overboard so they could save themselves. As decent people they resisted this suggestion until the critical moment when it became clear that within seconds they would all die. At that point, they listened and threw him into the turbulent depths. The storm abated immediately. Jonah thought his story had ended.

But it had just begun. He was swallowed by a whale, and miraculously survived. In the dark fetid innards of the whale, he recognized what he had never truly been willing to see, in his most exalted moments of prophecy, God's intimate knowledge and care over each life and each moment. He was a prophet and awareness of God was not a novelty to him. But recognition of the depths of God's mercy was.

It was then that Jonah did teshuva -- he repented, returning to God and the best in himself.

Now he recognized that no matter how painful the contrast between the Assyrians and the Jews would be to him, that God's motivation could only be one of mercy. Once he recognized this truth, he was willing to open the gates that he had closed so resolutely -- the gates of prayer. He was now ready for the most significant undertaking of his life.

The whale spit him out at the shores of Nineveh. He told the residents of Nineveh what awaited them: In forty days they could either make radical changes in their lives, or the city would be destroyed by God's wrath.

The changes in Nineveh happened with speed and drama. The king himself led the people into a total reformation. Nineveh's destruction was postponed for 40 years.

Everything that Jonah had feared had come to pass. The contrast that he dreaded was more vivid in reality than it was as a prophecy. He had only one further request that he be spared of seeing the destruction of his own people, which he knew would come eventually and at the hands of the Assyrians at that. The fact that the Jews would not take example from Nineveh would be the final act of callousness that would seal their fate. God did not answer Jonah's request with words. He answered by deed.

After Jonah left Nineveh, he went to the outskirts and made himself a shelter in the shade of a kikayon tree. It was a source of consolation to him in his anguish, and made him aware of God's compassion. But God sent a worm to eat through the branches and kill the tree.

In response, all the pent up feelings of agony poured forth from Jonah's lips. God replied "You took pity on a kikayon for which you did not labor ... Shall I not take pity on Nineveh, that great city in which there are more than 120 thousand people who do not know their right hand from their left, and many beasts as well?"

In short, what God was telling Jonah is the flaws of the residents of Nineveh did not make them unworthy of life. Each person is part of the world's spiritual ecology, and brings benefit to the world at least as much as the kikayon plant brought benefit to Jonah. [Continued]



Penitential Prayers

Exclusive to Yom Kippur is an entire selection of penitential prayers which are recited in each of the five prayers (after the silent Amidah in the evening service, and in the cantor's repetition in the other services). In the evening service the Ark is opened anew for each hymn, indicating opening a new dimension of the soul. Each hymn is followed by reciting the thirteen attributes of compassion – which were revealed to Moses atop Mt. Sinai before he descended on Yom Kippur. In total the Ark is opened five times corresponding to the five levels of the soul.

The penitential prayer in each of the five prayers consists of these special hymns:

Zachor Rachamecho – Remember your mercies (in Mussaf this is replaced with the Ten Martyrs – *eleh ezkera.*)

Zachor Lanu – Remember for us the covenant of the Patriarchs – Biblical quotations promising forgiveness.

Shema Koleinu – Hear our voice – heart-rending petitions to G-d imploring that he not reject us.

7. Congregant: Page 233 [326] זכור רחמים *Recite in English*

 *“O G-d, please cure.” This prayer is known as the ‘Selichos for Children’s Illnesses,’ and is recited on during an epidemic afflicting children. Each stanza ends with a reference to an historical instance when G-d intervened with a miraculous salvation.*

7 Page 235 [330] שמע קולנו *Recite in Hebrew and English*

 *“Ki Onu Amecha”*
We joyfully describe the unique closeness to G-d that we, as the Jewish nation, enjoy. It first lays out 12 aspects of the parallel relationship we have with G-d, and then 4 aspects of our sin and inadequacy, but G-d is merciful and infinite, therefore we confess our sins and seek His forgiveness.

 *“Oshamnu” (“We have transgressed”)*
The next section follows the order of the Hebrew alphabet and forms a general confession. We lightly hit our chest with our right hand while saying each phrase in this paragraph.

8 Talking Point #2 [Continued from previous talking point]

Yalkut Shimoni, the most encyclopedic of all Midrashim (written by Rav Shimon Hadarshan in the thirteenth century) gives us deep insight into the most profound recognition of Jonah's life:

At that moment he fell on his face and said, "Rule your world according to the attribute of mercy" as it is written "to You, God, is mercy and forgiveness."

The message of Jonah's prophecy is one for each one of us. We are taught that that Jonah's journey is one that we all make. We are born with a subconscious realization of the fact that we have a mission. We seek escape, because our mission is often one that we are afraid to attempt.

In the text of the Jonah story we are told that the places that he sought were Yaffo and Tarshish. While these places actually exist and are known as Jaffa and Tarsis, the literal meaning of the names of these cities are "beauty" and "wealth."

We comfort ourselves externally, by escaping from our inner knowledge of our mission through the pursuit of wealth, and by surrounding ourselves with beauty. Our bodies are compared to Jonah's ship. We face moments in life in which the fragility of our bodies is inescapable, as in when we face illness, or confront moments of danger that seem to last an eternity until they are resolved.

The sailors on the ship are the talents and capacities that work for us. They too cannot save us from our futile desire to escape ourselves. The whale is the symbol of ultimate confrontation of the recognition that our ultimate fate is the grave. For some, that recognition almost feels like a welcome refuge. For others, facing death forces them at last into pursuing life!

As with Jonah, our recognition of our own vulnerability can bring us to finally transcend our ego, surrendering our desire to control events, and beginning at last to accept our mission in life, no matter what it is.

We can suffer the vicissitudes of life, and recognize that we ourselves have caused the storms to toss us back and forth. We can move forward to fulfill our purpose, but we are still not free of conflict and anxiety until we finally recognize that every step along the way, we are embraced by Divine compassion.

It is then that we are ready to return to God. While for each of us the path is our own, and never yet explored by any other person, Jonah knew the beginning and the end of the journey that we all make.

Yom Kippur is the day in which each one of us can relive Jonah's journey. Let us finally move towards whatever the next step is for us in fulfilling the mission for which we were created. Let us use the time to return to God with joy and love.

☺ Sydney and his wife Miriam join their Synagogues' Hebrew Reading course. At the end of their first week, their teacher, Rabbi Bloom, goes over to Sydney and asks, "So tell me Sydney, what do you think of my Hebrew class?"

"It's not as bad as I thought it would be, Rabbi," replies Sydney.

"What do you mean by that?" asks Rabbi Bloom.

"If I'm honest, Rabbi, I must admit that I really only have to learn the first part of every Hebrew sentence."

"Why do you say that?" asks Rabbi Bloom. "Because, as she always does, Miriam finishes all my sentences for me."



We say the al chet while gently beating the chest, above the heart, which the seat of emotion. When we allow our emotions to overrule our minds, that leads to transgressing the will of G-d.

The Al Chet is broken down into four sections; in between each section we say: “for all these, G-d of pardon, pardon us, wipe away our sins, atone for us.”

*Pardon (selach) lightest – for sins we committed without even personal benefit
 Forgive (mechal) is stronger – for intentional sins done for personal benefit
 Atone (kapper) is the strongest – for unintentional sins, which can be entirely atoned for.*

47. Page 237 [333] על חטא...באנס וברצון - על חטא...ביודעים ובלא יודעים

Recite in English

48. ועל כלם  *Sing in Hebrew*

49.  Page 240[336] Congregant 1: David

50.  Page 240[337] Congregant 2: Do Not Fear

51.  Page 240[337] Congregant 3: Because

52.  Page 240[337] Congregant 4: A Day

53.  Page 240[337] Congregant 5: A Day On Which Moses

54.  Page 240[338] Congregant 6: A Day On Which Those Who Invoke

55.  Page 241[338] Congregant 7: A Day On Which You Will Look

56.  Page 241[338] Congregant 8: Who Is Like You

57.  Page 241[338] Congregant 9: As It Is Written

58. ובספר Page 243 [342] *Recite in English*

59. אבינו מלכנו Page 242 [341] *Recite in English*

60. אבינו מלכנו Page 243 [342] *Sing in Hebrew, first and last*
[Not said on שבת]

Yom Kippur Neilah

As Yom Kippur draws to a close and the shadows lengthen, we commence the Neilah Services. This special prayer, the only one of its kind in the entire year and perhaps the most emotional prayer of the day, is the climax of the holy day of Yom Kippur. The heavenly judgment inscribed on Rosh Hashanah is sealed at Neilah.

Neilah means closing, suggesting that the gates of heaven will soon shut and we must seize this last opportunity to pray with even greater devotion, concentration and intensity. Neilah must be said close to when the sun sets. Rashi states that the time of sunrise and sunset are auspicious moments for prayer.

The Neilah service contains stirring pleas that our prayers and supplications be accepted by G-d before Yom Kippur ends. The haunting melody of Neilah deepens the solemnity of the hour, stirring the emotions of the worshippers and rousing them to greater devotion and penitence. This is our final opportunity on Yom Kippur to ask for forgiveness for ourselves and our families.



Our souls are comprised of five spiritual levels. During the weekday, we access the three lower levels in our prayers. On Shabbat and holidays we access the fourth level. But it is only on Yom Kippur that it is possible for us to access the fifth, highest level – Yechidah – oneness with G-d, and only during Neilah, the final prayer service of the holiday.

The final, fifth service of Yom Kippur – Neilah – corresponds to the fifth and highest level of soul – Yechidah (Oneness) – which relates to our essence and our union with G-d. This is the highest point of the year – and of Yom Kippur – when the soul comes in touch with its source in G-d.



“Al Chet” - we do not recite the long confessional of “al chet” as Neilah as at the fifth level of soul, yechida - oneness with G-d, no sin is possible.

1. Talking Point #1

Neilah Corresponds to the fifth and highest dimension of the soul, the holy of holies of the soul which we access only on this one day at this one time. We do not recite the long confessional of “al chet” as Neilah as at the fifth level of soul, *yechida* - oneness with G-d, no sin is possible.

This is because during Neilah, before the gates are locked, everything is open and we are able to reach even Yechidah (oneness, our essence) which is the most intimate, vulnerable, gentle part of the soul of the human being.

Neilah, means closing. Telling us that the gates of heaven are about to close, reminding us to seize this last opportunity to pray, ask, beg with even greater devotion, concentration and intensity.

Neilah contains stirring pleas that our prayers and supplications be accepted by G-d as Yom Kippur comes to an end. This is the final opportunity to ask for ourselves, our children, and families, for a healthy, prosperous and sweet year.

2. Page 255 [358] מסוד *Recite in English*
3. Page 255 [359] זכרנו *Recite in English*
4. Page 256 [360] שערי *Recite in English*
5. Page 256 [360] כתר *Sing in Hebrew*
6. Talking Point #2

In the context of prayer, Yom Kippur stands out among all other days and holidays.

On an ordinary weekday, we say three prayers: morning (Shachrit), afternoon (Minchah) and night (Maariv), corresponding to the three time zones of prayer that were initiated by the three patriarchs: Avraham, Yitzchak and Yaakov, respectively. These time zones correlated in Temple times to the daily offerings. On Shabbat and on the holidays, there was extra offering known as the Musaf ("extra"), and today we say a fourth Musaf prayer on the Shabbat and on the holidays.

But on Yom Kippur, an extraordinary fifth prayer is added: Neilah "Closing of the Gates." This either refers to the closing of the Temple gates at the end of the day or this alludes to the closing of the gates of heaven, as the day is coming to a close.

On the two days of Rosh Hashanah (considered a single "extended day"), we pray eight times; on Yom Kippur we pray five times. But, according to a mystical principle, each of Yom Kippur's five prayers comprises ten, for a total of 50. Altogether the prayers of the Days of Awe number 58 (which is the numerical value of the Hebrew word *chen* meaning "grace." These 58 prayers are meant to elicit G-d's grace for the renewal of creation on Rosh Hashanah and to forgive iniquity on Yom Kippur. "The poor use entreaties," says King Shlomo in his

Proverbs (18:23), for *chen* represents the most beloved aspect of prayer.

According to Kabbalah, each of these prayers has the power to access a different level of soul, as follows:

	Level of Soul	Prayer
5	<i>Yechidah</i> (Unique One)	<i>Neilah</i> (Locking of the Gates)
4	<i>Chayah</i> (Living One)	<i>Musaf</i> (Extra)
3	<i>Neshama</i> (Breath of Life)	<i>Minchah</i> (Afternoon)
2	<i>Ruach</i> (Spirit)	<i>Shachrit</i> (Morning)
1	<i>Nefesh</i> (Life Force)	<i>Maariv</i> (Evening)

The *nefesh* is the lowest and densest level of the soul, the part of the soul that most clearly interfaces with the physical. It is the *nefesh* that ensures survival and impels the body to nourish and protect itself. For the most part, the *nefesh* represents functional consciousness.

The *ruach* manifests as emotional consciousness. It gives us the spiritual ability to rise above immediate existential needs and appreciate matters of emotional value. Music and all the fine arts are expressions of *ruach*, albeit in its lowest form.

The *neshama* is the soul level of our intellectual ability. It gives us the power to rise above ourselves and elect our own destiny by exercising our freedom of choice. It helps us see beyond ourselves and catch a glimpse of transcendence.

The *chayah* is the level of our dearest will, our want to be one with our source in G-d. With this level of soul, we not only have an awareness of transcendence but, in fact, do transcend.

The *yeichidah* is the highest, deepest, most profound level of soul—it represents uniqueness, oneness. It is the part of us that does not seek oneness, but is one with the Ultimate One.

Neilah gives us the chance to reach this the fifth level of soul, *yeichidah*. As the sun is setting and the heavenly gates are slowly closing, we are faced with a moment of truth, and we respond by a full awakening of the deepest level of our soul.

As we recite the fifth and last prayer, we enter the deepest chamber above, and we move heaven to arouse Divine blessings for *Ketivah Vechatima Tova*, so that we

are "written and sealed for good"—physically, emotionally, mentally and spiritually.

During the course of Yom Kippur we rip our hearts asunder, we open up completely, for this is what real teshuvah is all about, exposing ourselves, facing ourselves honestly. And so, as the day comes to a close, we recite this lofty neilah, which also means closing up, as in a closing-up prayer, putting everything that was spilled out back, and reintegrating and becoming whole again.

7. Page 259 [364] פתח *Recite in English*
8. Page 259 [364] א-ל מלך *Recite in English*
9. Page 259 [365] ה' ה' *Sing in Hebrew*
10. 🗣️ Congregant: Page 260 [366] מרובים *Recite in English*
11. 🎵 Page 262 [369] אזכרה א-להים TTO: א-לי אתה
12. Page 262 [370] רחם *Recite in English*
13. Talking Point #3

The Cantonists were child-recruits in the Russian military. The Russian Tzar, Peter the Great, devised the system in which young men were drafted to serve in the military for prolonged terms. Tzar Nicholas Pavolovich (1827-1855) used this system as a vehicle to force Jewish children to accept Baptism. The children were literally stolen from their homes in the shtetles and forced to serve long extended terms as trainees and then as soldiers when they reached the age of eighteen. They faced severe pressure by all means including torture to accept baptism. Prior Russian Tzars may have repeatedly failed to induce the Jews of the Pale Settlement to abandon their faith, but Nicholas was determined to enforce his will upon the children.

One Yom Kippur, at Neilah time, a Cantonist entered a shul indicating that he most probably had never succumbed to the enormous pressure to accept Baptism. Had he undergone Baptism, he would have been officially listed as a Christian and prohibited from ever entering a synagogue during the reign of Nicholas.

The congregation appointed the Cantonist to lead the Neilah prayers -- the most hallowed moment of the year. This was a great honor, especially for a guest. The gesture clearly demonstrated one of great admiration for the man who tenaciously held on to his faith at all costs.

The soldier of Tzar Nicholas made his way to the front of the shul. Having forgotten almost all the religious training he had received as a child including the ability to read Hebrew, he could not recite, nor lead the Neilah prayers. However, before the congregation, he expressed a powerful prayer from the heart, which shook the entire congregation. He proclaimed, "Father in Heaven, what shall I pray for? I can not pray for children for I never got married and have no hope to raise a family, I am too old to start anew. I can't pray for life, for what value is such a life? It would be better for me if I died. I can not pray to be able to make a living since Nicholas provides for my daily food. The only thing I can pray for is, "Yisgadal VeYoiskadash Shmei Rabah" meaning "May your name be blessed forever" (from the Kaddish).

When hearing these words, the entire congregation wept. They wept over the plight of the poor individual and his difficult life of travail. They also wept for the tens of thousands of other Cantonists who were forced to endure the same hardships, as well as their families, and communities who were forced to endure the losses of so many of their sons and brothers. Many Cantonists had died from the rigors, or had accepted Baptism, others were simply lost in Siberia hundreds of miles away from their homes. All Jewish communities of Russia were faced with the Tzars' quotas of providing recruits.

The Tzar issued the orders, the leaders of each town's Kahal (Jewish communal organization) which for the most part perceived non-compliance as not an option, provided the recruits, and the Chappers (kidnappers) did the dirty work of the Kahal for a fee. Many Kahal leaders could not simply argue that they had no choice. It was the poor, who were the recruits, and many Kahal officials profited from payments from the wealthy for their sons' exemptions. How demoralizing and traumatizing that era was for the Jews of Russia! That too was no doubt part of Nicholas' strategy. All Jews who lived under the Tzar's rule were no doubt effected by the horrors of this era.

On Yom Kippur, at the moment of Neilah, a congregation was confronted with the horrors of that era by the heartfelt words of a true hero. A hero who was one of thousands who stood against Nicholas and displayed a type of heroism unusual for adults, let alone children. In his own words, he added untold significance to that

moment of Neilah. He reminded the congregation of the many heroes of that era. On that Yom Kippur day, the moment of Neilah was truly one of reckoning and regret for all Jews, even those not present.

This moving story reminds us that at the height of our prayers, when the very core of our heart is stirred, we must never forget those “unsung heroes”. The countless Jewish children, both figuratively and in actuality who are unfortunately not even able to be in Synagogue with us this evening to pray. We must pray for them, we must feel for them and say “yisgadal veyiskadash” for them as well.

14. Page 267 [375] אבינו מלכנו *Recite in English*
15. Page 268 [376] ובספר *Recite in English*
16. Page 268 [376] אבינו מלכנו *Sing in Hebrew, first and last*
[Recited even on שבת]
17. Talking Point #4

Shema, Hashem Hu, and the Shofar

We conclude the Neilah with the blowing of the shofar and the thunderous declaration of Shema ("Hear O Israel, G-D is our G-d, G-D is one"), we then shout out Baruch Shem ("Blessed be the name of His glorious kingdom forever and ever") three times, and HaShem Hu Elokim ("G-D, He is G-d!") seven times.

Having reached this point in prayer, we can loudly declare our firm belief in the absolute oneness of the Creator, and our willingness to live and die by this truth. We have journeyed inwards and upwards, and our unequivocal affirmation of oneness is absolute.

Then, we continue with the angelic praise of Baruch Shem and loudly pronounce it three times, demonstrating that G-d's oneness permeates all dimensions of our reality—past, present and future.

HaShem Hu Elokim is a declaration that comes from the Book of Kings (18:39) which relates the confrontation between the Prophet Eliyahu and the 450 priests of the pagan deity Ba'al. To save the Jewish people from their idolatrous influences, Eliyahu had challenged the priests of Ba'al to offer a sacrifice alongside his sacrifice, in order to see which would be accepted first by a fire from heaven. Although the priests prayed and cried to Ba'al all day, their sacrificial bull only lay

rotting on its altar. However, when it came Eliyahu's turn, he uttered only one short prayer and a pillar of fire immediately descended, consuming not only the sacrifice but the altar as well. The people gathered there then loudly proclaimed: HaShem Hu Elokim! HaShem Hu Elokim!

Among the names of G-d listed in the Torah, the two of this declaration are the most significant. The essential four-letter name of G-d, the Tetragrammaton—which we are forbidden to pronounce and which we generally render as HaShem (meaning "The Name") or in prayer as Adonai (most often translated as "Lord")—stands for G-d's transcendence. The name of G-d, Elokim (which we translate as "Almighty" or "G-d"), stands for G-d's immanence, G-d's manifestation as Creator of nature.

The declaration HaShem Hu Elokim testifies there is only Oneness—the Creator's immanence and transcendence are part of the same. There is absolute unity, and everything in the universe of the many is included in the Creator's Oneness.

When the Jewish people first uttered this declaration after witnessing Eliyahu's demonstration, they affirmed this fact, which stands counter to the beliefs of idolatry that present a part as the whole, fragmenting one force and believing it to be "the All."

HaShem Hu Elokim is a statement of our awareness that there is only One, that all is absolute unity. Such a declaration can only occur at the pinnacle of the Yom Kippur experience.

Blowing of the shofar symbolizes the ascent of the Divine Presence, the Shechinah, that has rested upon us and upon the day, as it says "G-d ascends with a teruah [sound of the shofar]." The declaration of HaShem Hu Elokim repeated seven times accompanies the Shechinah as it ascends above the "seven heavens," returning to its source of emanation.

The blowing of the shofar is a sign of confidence—we are showing that we are confident that G-d has accepted our prayers. It is a Chabad custom to rise up in joyful song at this point. There is a tremendous spiritual relief that sweeps over the community as the prayers of Yom Kippur are coming to a close—we have unburdened ourselves of the negativity that has weighed us down, and we feel good that our prayers were accepted on high.

From a place of personal redemption, we express our yearning for global salvation—a yearning to have our exile come to an end, to return to Yerushalayim where we belong.



Significance of the sequence 1 – 3 – 7

Shemah is said once, declaring G-d's absolute Unity – Yechida/Atzilus.

Boruch Shem three times signifies our effort to infuse the unity of yechidah into the three dimensions of existence: nefesh, ruach, neshamah (three worlds of Beriyah, Yetzirah, Asiyah).

Seven times Hashem Hu HaElokim is a further infusion of the unity into the seven (emotional) faculties of each level of the soul (the seven levels in each world). These seven also elevate us through the seven heavens as the Divine presence on Yom Kippur returns upward with the conclusion of the day.

We then integrate and conclude this yechida experience of unity with the saying of kaddish, in which we sing a victory march, known as Napoleon's March appropriated by the first Lubavitcher Rebbe, the Alter Rebbe, demonstrating our triumph against all physical and spiritual adversaries.

This is followed by the blast of the Shofar, which is the level of the Shofar G-dol (the Great Shofar) that will be heard with the coming of Moshiach, as we declare: Next Year in Jerusalem! May it happen now, and then we will inevitably be in Jerusalem by next year.

- 18. Page 270 [379] ה'ברוך/שמע *Recite in Hebrew*
- 19. 🎵 Page 270 [379] מארש נאפוליאן / Napoleon's March
- 20. Talking Point #5 - Yom Kippur Closing Words

Higher Teshuvah

What now?

Have we not already cleaned our slate? So why are we again praying for forgiveness in the Amidah of Maariv following Yom Kippur prayers?

There is a Chassidic saying that, after Yom Kippur, the first thing we need to do is teshuvah. What can that mean?

There is a story told about Rabbi Saadiah Gaon, the 9th century Babylonian sage, that may shed some light. Once he was asked by his students why he was in a constant state of teshuvah. He replied that on one of his many trips, he spent a night at an inn, and the inn-keeper, being a pious individual, treated him very nicely as he did all his guests. The next morning, when the inn-keeper saw a huge crowd gathered at his inn to greet the great sage, he realized who his guest was. Some time later, with a bitter heart, the inn-keeper came to ask forgiveness from Rabbi Saadiah for the way he treated him. "But why are you apologizing?," the great rabbi asked, "You treated me so nicely." The inn-keeper replied, "No, I treated you as I would all other guests, but had I known who you were, I would have treated you as was fitting for a man of your stature."

This experience, Rabbi Saadiah said, caused him to be in a constant state of teshuvah. As he explained, "Everyday that I live, I gain in my knowledge, awareness and understanding, and everyday I realize that compared to my understanding today, there is much more room to grow. Everyday, indeed every moment, calls forth for new measures of return."

New possibilities—undiscovered spiritual opportunities—are opened to us with every new day lived. A new day can bring greater awareness and understanding, and with the new awareness can come a renewed understanding of our true and deeper potential. We learn how much more we can improve, and how much further we can grow.

If ever there was the perfect time to resolve and accept upon oneself a greater and more profound level of teshuvah, it is now, right after Yom Kippur. And so, at the end of this great day, we immediately begin the process of teshuvah—for teshuvah, as a reflection of life and growth, is continuous and ever evolving, bringing us always to new heights, but now our teshuvah is with love and integration, and spiritual elation.

The Joy of being Freed

When we are forgiven, we feel relief and are overjoyed. Though on a conscious level, we may not know whether we are forgiven or not, but the fact that there is great palpable joy felt in the air as Yom Kippur comes to an end is proof that we have all been forgiven. Deeply our souls sense this cleansing and feel purified and free.

As Yom Kippur comes to a close, a heavenly voice rings out, "Go your way, eat your bread with joy, and drink your wine with a merry heart; for G-d has already accepted your works." (Ecclesiastes 9:7.) It is a time of great joy, as our teshuvah has been accepted, and our repairs are complete.

Customarily, we speak about building a sukkah, the booth of the holiday of Sukkot, which is referred to as "the time of Joy."

ANNOUNCEMENTS

The Holiday of Sukkot begins this Wednesday evening. Please join us for Holiday services on:

Wednesday Evening:	6:30 PM – Evening Services followed by a Community Sukkot Dinner
Thursday Morning:	8:00 AM - Come Shake the lulav and etrog - Followed by a Kiddush in the Sukkah
Thursday Evening:	7:00 PM
Friday Morning:	8:00 AM - Come Shake the lulav and etrog - Followed by a Kiddush in the Sukkah

Please make sure to mark your calendars: **Simchat Torah** begins on Thursday evening, October 20. Hakafot will begin at 6:30 PM – bring your family bring the kids for much fun and dancing.

Simchat Torah daytime services and Hakafot are on Friday morning, October 21 and begin at 8:00 AM.